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The Limits of Party Cues in Multi-Level Systems

How Within-Party Disagreement Shapes Partisan Cue-Taking

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Abstract

Party cues help partisans form policy preferences. Yet in multi-level systems, parties are not always unitary cue-givers. While operating under the same party label, national and regional party units may send conflicting policy signals. In this thesis, I examine how partisans respond to within-party cue cross-pressure, defined as the simultaneous exposure to divergent in-party cues. I argue that divergence weakens the effect of party cues and that partisans resolve cue-conflict by privileging the national party unit. I test these expectations with an online vignette experiment with 124 Austrian partisans in which respondents are either exposed to a unified cue or a divergence cue condition, where one of the two party units takes an opposing stance, while the other party unit supported an electricity-system reform proposal. The results show that unified endorsement relative to divergence significantly increases policy support. This suggests that party cues are more effective when party units signal a coherent position. However, there is no significant evidence that partisans systematically follow the national party unit under conflict. Leveraging theoretically relevant measures of respondents' considerations after treatment exposure and open-ended statements indicates that respondents do not apply a stable national-level decision rule. Instead, cue divergence produced various forms of reasoning, including effortful issue-based evaluation. By studying parties as internally differentiated cue-givers, this thesis shows that partisan cue-taking depends on more than party identity alone. In multi-level systems, the coherence in policy endorsements conditions whether party cues retain their heuristic value, while cross-level disagreement makes opinion formation more contingent.

Key Words

Public opinion, party cues, multi-level systems, intra-party disagreement, experimental research

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Introduction

Political parties structure electoral competition and representation, and provide citizens with signals about which policies to support (Pitkin, 1967; Zaller, 1992; Powell, 2004; Tesler and Zaller, 2014). In much of the party cue literature, this signaling function is treated as a relatively straightforward mechanism: party actors endorse a position, individuals recognize the cue in media, and may use it to inform their political judgment (Sniderman, Brody and Tetlock, 1991; Lupia and McCubbins, 1998; Bullock, 2020; Slothuus and Bisgaard, 2021).

This chain of reasoning becomes more difficult to sustain in multi-level systems, where parties are not single, uniform actors (Deschouwer, 2003; Carty, 2004; Bolleyer, 2012). National and regional party units may operate under a shared party label while responding to different institutional responsibilities, territorial electoral incentives, and regional political constraints (Müller, 2013; Cabeza, Gómez and Alonso, 2017; Däubler, Müller and Stecker, 2018; Gross and Krauss, 2021; Enns-Jedenastik *et al.*, 2022; Krauss, Praprotnik and Gross, 2025). Parties in multi-level political systems can therefore speak with more than one voice. For partisans, this creates an informational problem: their preferred party may still be a relevant source of information, but it no longer provides a single policy position to follow.

The central question of this thesis is *how do partisans react to divergent in-party cues across levels of government?* I conceptualize the informational problem of such situations as *within-party cue cross-pressure*: the simultaneous exposure to divergent cues originating from units in the in-party organization. I first argue that when national and regional party units jointly endorse a proposal, partisans receive a clear in-party signal and the cue can function as a straightforward heuristic (Bullock, 2020). When the two party units take opposing positions, this shortcut becomes less useful. Partisanship still indicates which party to trust, but not which intra-party position to follow. I therefore expect support for a proposal to be higher under unified endorsement than under cue divergence (H1). I then argue that, under cue divergence, partisans may rely on secondary heuristics that help them decide which of the competing signals to follow.

To resolve cue divergence, partisans will on average assign greater weight to the national party unit (H2). This rests on two distinct but compatible mechanisms. The first, persuasion-based logic, builds on Lupia and McCubbins' (1998) theory of persuasion: The national party unit may appear more knowledgeable about policy implications and more constrained by reputational costs if it endorsed a flawed proposal. The second, authority-based logic, instead concerns intra-party legitimacy: the national party unit may be perceived as more entitled to define *the* party line and coordinate coherence in party-wide representation. Both logics imply that when national and regional party units disagree, partisans should be more influenced by the national-level cue.

To test these expectations, I field a three-arm online vignette experiment with 124 self-declared Austrian partisans. Austria is a suitable case because it combines nationally integrated party competition with recognizable regional branches and meaningful subnational governance authority. Respondents were randomly assigned to a hypothetical news-style vignette about an electricity-system reform proposal. In the unified endorsement condition, both the national and state party organization of the respondents' preferred party supported the proposal. In the two divergence conditions, the party units took opposing positions, with either the national or the state party unit supporting the proposal and the other unit opposing it. The primary outcome measure is expressed policy support. Post-treatment perception items on the theoretical mechanisms and open-ended responses are used descriptively to explore how respondents made sense of within-party cue cross-pressure.

The findings are mixed but theoretically informative. Unified endorsement significantly increases policy support relative to cue divergence, suggesting that unified party cues preserve the heuristic value of the party signal. However, the evidence does not show that partisans systematically follow the national party unit under divergence. Although respondents tend to perceive the national party unit as more knowledgeable, more reputationally constrained, and more authoritative, these considerations did not translate into higher support when the national party endorsed and lower support when it opposed the reform proposal. Open-ended responses point to heterogeneous forms of reasoning, including reliance on national-level expertise, regional proximity and local knowledge, as well as issue-based evaluation.

With this thesis, I contribute to the literature by relaxing the assumption that parties speak with one voice. In multi-level systems, parties operate as multi-tiered cue-givers, and the effect of in-party cues depends not only on their partisan source but also on whether the cues appear coherent. The findings show that cross-level disagreement has measurable consequences for partisan opinion formation, possibly increasing reliance on effortful, systematic reasoning. Cue-taking under within-party competition in multi-level systems therefore appears less hierarchical, more contingent, and more cognitively demanding than a simple national-level heuristic logic would imply.

Literature Review

A large body of research shows that party communication substantially shapes citizens' policy preferences and political judgments (Tesler and Zaller, 2014; Bullock, 2020; Slothuus and Bisgaard, 2021; Coppock, 2023), particularly in the form of party cues, which are messages "that people use to infer other information and, by extension, to make decisions" (Bullock, 2020, p. 129). Party cues allow citizens to navigate competing positions in public policy debates and to form judgments without evaluating every policy proposal in detail (Sniderman, Brody and Tetlock, 1991; Lupia and McCubbins, 1998). Two primary reasons for why voters use party cues in political judgment have been put forward: motivated reasoning and dual-process models.

Motivated Reasoning and Dual-Process Models

The motivated reasoning framework places strong emphasis on partisan identity and directional goals as drivers of cue-taking (Kunda, 1990; Lodge and Taber, 2013). Party cues prime judgment for partisan identity, making partisan goals salient in reasoning and shaping subsequent stages of policy evaluation (Goren, Federico and Kittilson, 2009; Petersen *et al.*, 2013; Green, Palmquist and Schickler, 2017; Groenendyk and Krupnikov, 2021). A key implication is that citizens tend to arrive at conclusions that are congruent with their political identity, their partisan commitment or prior ideological preferences (Kunda, 1990; Groenendyk, 2013; Bullock, 2020).

Consistent with this perspective, a large body of research shows that cue effects are generally stronger for in-party than for out-party cues (Goren, Federico and Kittilson, 2009; Groenendyk, 2013; Green, Palmquist and Schickler, 2017; Coppock, 2023), for strong partisans (Bullock, 2020), or in polarized environments (Druckman, Peterson and Slothuus, 2013). These findings highlight the powerful, yet conditional, role of motivated reasoning in shaping responses to elite communication.

Nonetheless, motivated reasoning does not yield clear theoretical predictions for situations in which different organizational units of the same party send conflicting cues on a policy proposal. Under these circumstances, partisan identity no longer explicitly provides directional guidance and it becomes unclear which signal is most consistent with one's partisan commitments. Hence, while motivated reasoning generally shapes how individuals process information and tend to maintain partisan consistency in preference formation, it offers limited guidance for resolving the ambiguity of competitive within-party cueing environments. From a theoretical viewpoint, these situations are better addressed by dual-process models that emphasize the importance of heuristic inference.

Under the dual-process perspective, policy preferences are the product of two modes of information processing: an effortful, systematic mode and a fast, heuristic-based mode (Eagly and Chaiken, 1993; Kahneman, 2011). In the systematic mode, individuals carefully scrutinize available information, but doing so requires substantial cognitive effort and motivation (Bullock, 2020). By contrast, the heuristic mode allows individuals to form judgments with far lower cognitive demands. It directs attention to the most essential pieces of information, thereby functioning as a shortcut or heuristic (Lau and Redlawsk, 2001; Kahneman, 2011; Kahneman, Slovic and Tversky, 2013).

Party cues are one such heuristic, packaging politically relevant information into a dense and useful format for political judgment: the party label and the direction of endorsement on the policy in question (Leeper and Slothuus, 2014). By taking the messages of their preferred party at face value, partisans can adopt attitudes that are broadly consistent with their partisan commitments even when they are not fully engaged with the substantive details of a policy debate (Downs, 1968; Sniderman, Brody and Tetlock,

1991; Lupia, 1994; Lupia and McCubbins, 1998). Partisanship thus remains central, not because it implies directional reasoning in line with pre-determined conclusions as it does under motivated reasoning (Kunda, 1990; Lodge and Taber, 2013), but because it provides a basis for evaluating competing political standpoints efficiently and quick (Carmines and Kuklinski, 1990).

Within the dual-process framework, several factors are known to moderate the use and effectiveness of party cues. One is political sophistication, since individuals who are better able to scrutinize political information are also better able to evaluate party cues (Arceneaux and Vander Wielen, 2017; Bullock, 2020). Cue clarity shapes reliance on cues as well, where individuals exposed to clearer ideological messages can navigate issue competition more easily (Brader, Tucker and Duell, 2013; Bullock, 2020). In addition, salience of an issue moderates cue-taking, as issue salience increases the likelihood that individuals hold prior views (Lecheler, de Vreese and Slothuus, 2009), which reduce the persuasiveness of party cues (Boudreau and MacKenzie, 2014; Arceneaux and Vander Wielen, 2017; Tappin, 2023). Finally, the provision of additional policy-relevant information (Bullock, 2011) and real-world framing and packaging (Skytte, 2025) tends to reduce, but not eliminate, the influence of party cues.

Dual-process models hence conceptualize cue-taking as a conditional heuristic mechanism shaped by individual capacities, motivations and effort, prior attitudes and features of the information environment. However, this literature largely assumes that party cues themselves are consistent and originate from a unified party source, implicitly treating parties as unitary cue-givers and often studying effects of single cues in isolation.

Party Cues in Multi-Level Systems

In multi-level systems, however, partisans may face simultaneous, conflicting cues from different organizational units of their party¹, because incentives vary across the national, regional, and local political arenas. While members of a party aim to maintain cohesion within the overarching party organization (Deschouwer, 2003; Carty, 2004; Bolleyer, 2012), individual party units and branches can pursue independent policy-, office-, and vote-seeking goals within their respective arena (Strøm, 1990).²

This mix of institutional and organizational incentives can produce substantial differences in issue strategies (Ennser-Jedenastik *et al.*, 2022; Krauss, Praprotnik and Gross, 2025), policy priorities (Müller, 2013; Alonso, Cabeza and Gómez, 2017; Cabeza, Gómez and Alonso, 2017), and coalition or governing agendas (Gross and Krauss, 2021). Crucially, media reporting makes such intra-party policy divergences

¹ An Austrian example would be the *[Party label] Bundespartei* as the national party unit and *[Party label] Burgenland* or *[Party label] Wien* as regional party units.

² Here, the *national party unit* incorporates national-level party elites in parliamentary systems, including party leaders, general secretaries, parliamentary party leaders, and where applicable, members of the executive government. The mirrored structure of intermediary office-holders and party officials at the sub-national, regional level is referred to by the term *regional party unit*.

visible, thereby providing the informational basis for partisans to perceive multiple, potentially competing cues from their preferred party (Stanyer, 2001; Strömbäck, 2008; Djerf-Pierre and Shehata, 2017).

Existing research on political behavior in European multi-level systems has primarily focused on spillover effects in voting behavior, rather than on how citizens process competing in-party cues in political reasoning. Studies examine, for example, how regional campaigning events affect national-level vote intentions (Bechtel, 2012), how local policy output shapes parties' national-level electoral performance (Geys and Vermeir, 2014), and how multi-level governance structures permit spillover evaluations of incumbents (Schönhage and Geys, 2021).

More closely related to the present thesis, Filindra and Harbridge-Yong (2022) examine how partisans respond to intra-party conflict in a hierarchical setting. Using experimental evidence from the US, they show that partisans tend to side with party leaders when subordinate co-partisan elites criticize leadership misconduct, which they attribute to the centrality of party leaders within the partisan in-group. Agadjanian (2020) provides related evidence for a robust “follow-the-leader” dynamic, showing that party leader cues retain substantial influence even when partisans are exposed to divergent in-party elite cues or policy information. Together, these studies suggest that not all in-party speakers are equally influential and that party hierarchy can shape how partisans evaluate competing co-partisan messages.

However, this line of research remains limited in two important respects. First, Filindra and Harbridge-Yong (2022) focus on elite conflict over leadership misconduct rather than conflict over policy substance. Agadjanian (2020) does examine policy cues but specifically tests whether leader influences persists when leaders endorse realistically designed counter-stereotypical policy positions, when partisans encounter additional co-partisan elite cues or when made aware of negative policy implications. Second, both studies examine cues from individual elites in the US two-party system, rather than conflict between organizational party units in a multi-level parliamentary system.

This gap also reflects a broader limitation in persuasion research. As Druckman (2021) argues, studies of political persuasion often examine party messages in isolation, while paying less attention to settings where multiple individual or collective actors compete to shape opinions simultaneously (DellaVigna and Gentzkow, 2010; Druckman, 2021). This thesis addresses this limitation by examining within-party cue competition in a multi-level system. It shows how disagreement between national and regional party units creates cross-pressure in which partisans must evaluate not only the policy signal itself but also decide which co-partisan source to follow.

Cross-pressure is not an entirely novel concept. Research on this idea seeks to understand how individuals navigate competing considerations in political behavior (Cartwright and Zander, 1968; Converse and Campbell, 1968). Such tensions have recently been recognized to be caused by competing identities (Brader, Tucker and Theriault, 2014), multiple group memberships (Dassonneville, 2022), and cross-cutting preferences across ideological dimensions (Lefkofridi, Wagner and Willmann, 2014).

Applying this to the context of elite communication and policy judgment, Vrânceanu (2022) focuses on the influence of competing cues as cross-pressure on policy preferences. She shows that incongruent shifts in co-partisan cues on the immigration issue moves partisans' preferences. Responses to cross-pressure, in this case between prior attitudes and in-party signals that challenge them, can therefore be understood through a dual-process lens. Applying this insight to a situation where different party units send diverging cues, I primarily rely on dual-processing as the primary mechanism to examine how partisans can resolve within-party cue cross-pressure.

Research Gap and Research Question

While a large body of research has investigated partisan responses to in-party cues, existing research does not specify how partisans resolve situations in which *competing* cues originate *simultaneously* from different organizational units *across* levels from *within* the same party organization. I refer to this informational problem as *within-party cue cross-pressure*: the simultaneous exposure to divergent cues originating from units in the in-party organization.

In such contexts, both dominant theoretical perspectives face important limitations. Motivated reasoning accounts emphasize directional partisan goals and the construction of judgments consistent with prior commitments. However, when different organizational units of one's preferred party send conflicting cues on the same policy proposal, partisan goals do not provide immediate guidance on which position is consistent with their partisan identity. Dual-process models offer a more suitable starting point because they conceptualize party cues as heuristic shortcuts. Yet existing dual-process arguments do not specify how partisans react when co-partisan cues diverge, nor which inferential rules they apply when competing in-party sources simultaneously seek to influence opinion.

In the subsequent theoretical argument, I therefore examine whether partisans resolve within-party cue cross-pressure through heuristic inference. Specifically, I ask whether partisans rely on cue-giver attributes such as perceived knowledge, reputational constraint, and authority when deciding which in-party source to follow. I hence aim to answer the research question:

How do partisans react to divergent in-party cues across levels of government?

Theory

Consider a competitive persuasion environment in which multiple co-partisan units simultaneously provide cues, requiring partisans to evaluate them relative to one another. For the purposes of the argument, I adopt a stylized communication setting, restricting the information environment to ensure parsimony of the argument.

When both party units express support for the proposal, partisans receive congruent in-party cues. In this information environment, the party appears united and partisans can infer a clear party position. As dual-process models suggest, partisanship can function as a straightforward heuristic for political judgment (Bullock, 2020). Consistent with prior research showing that cue effects tend to be stronger when party cues are coherent and clear (Brader, Tucker and Duell, 2013; Bullock, 2020), I expect support for the proposal to be higher under unified endorsement than cue divergence.

Hypothesis H1: Unified Endorsement Effect

Average support among partisans for a policy proposal is higher when the national and a regional party unit of their preferred party jointly endorse the proposal than when these units express opposing positions.

When the two party units take opposing positions, partisans likely face a more demanding inferential task. Under within-party cue cross-pressure, partisan identity still indicates which party is preferred, but no longer which in-party position to adopt. Dual process models predict that, rather than engaging in cognitively demanding policy evaluation, many partisans are likely to rely on additional heuristics to resolve the conflict and form a policy judgment (Bullock, 2020). I argue that two distinct heuristic logics derive the same expectation: partisans will follow the national-level cue over the sub-national cue.

In the first logic partisans compare the two party units and implicitly assess which one appears more persuasive. Drawing on Lupia and McCubbins (1998), persuasion depends on whether a speaker is perceived as knowledgeable and facing reputational constraint to communicate sincerely. I argue that under within-party cue cross-pressure, partisans are likely to perceive the national party unit as superior on both dimensions. This expectation follows from the perceived hierarchy of political levels. Such a hierarchy may be available as a prior belief or become salient once partisans encounter national and regional party labels. Research on second-order elections suggests that voters tend to treat the national arena as the primary arena of political competition (Reif and Schmitt, 1980; Norris and Reif, 1997), even though this hierarchy varies across contexts (Schakel and Jeffery, 2013). If partisans perceive national and regional arenas as unequal in electoral importance, I argue they are also likely to extend this hierarchy to the corresponding party units on relevant criteria.

First, the perceived hierarchy may inform judgments about policy knowledge. National party units are often presumed to have greater resources to assess policy implications (Bolleyer, 2012) and are more visibly tied to system-wide strategy, parliamentary politics, and the party organization's overall public standing (Duverger, 1963; Kirchheimer, 1966). Even without detailed knowledge of intra-party policymaking, partisans may therefore infer that the national party unit is better placed to evaluate which policy position serves the party's broader strategic and ideological goals (Carty, 2004; Bolleyer, 2012). The behavior of regional branches, by contrast, may be perceived as more strongly shaped by territorially bounded incentives (Deschouwer, 2003) and subnational goals (Strøm, 1990). The national-level cue-giver should therefore appear more knowledgeable to most partisans. Not because national actors are objectively better informed in all cases³, but because cues issued under the national party label are more closely associated with system-wide oversight, party reputation, and broader policy judgment.

Second, perceptions of the party hierarchy may also inform judgments about reputational constraint. Because national party units are exposed to system-wide electoral accountability and public scrutiny, partisans plausibly infer that their endorsements are issued under greater reputational constraint. Drawing again on second-order election arguments (Reif and Schmitt, 1980), voters are often argued to treat the national arena as the primary locus of accountability. As a result, individuals may perceive policy endorsements from the national level to carry higher stakes for the party's overall public reputation. These communicative costs inform expectations about how party actors should behave (Strøm, 1990): national-level units may be seen as more constrained to adopt positions that are defensible and less likely to backfire. To the contrary, regional party units may appear having greater flexibility to advance locally advantageous positions, primarily addressing their respective sub-national domain of politics. These considerations imply that national-level party units face greater reputational constraints, not necessarily because the national party unit is directly accountable for every policy issue, but because the public and news media expects their endorsements to apply across the system.

Taken together, this suggests that the national party unit is likely perceived to be both better informed of policy implications and more constrained to not endorse flawed policy proposals. Utilizing these perceptual considerations to draw epistemic inferences, as Lupia & McCubbins (1998) theory of persuasion foresees, partisans will likely view the national party unit as the more persuasive source and be more influenced by its policy cue.

A second, distinct logic leading to the same observable outcome is authority-based. Here, the main logic is that partisans assign different levels of authority to define the party's official line. In European multi-level organizations, national party units typically occupy the central coordinating role and serve as the

³ On strongly regionalized or locally embedded issues, regional party units may plausibly be perceived as more knowledgeable. The argument here concerns the general heuristic implication of national and regional party labels under within-party cue cross-pressure and regards issue domain as a scope condition.

main reference point for party-wide representation (Deschouwer, 2003). Even where parties are not strictly hierarchical, the national unit is usually the most visible claimant to speak for the party as a whole (Carty, 2004; Bolleyer, 2012). As the representative core of the party, it is likely to be attributed greater authority than its sub-national counterparts to define policy priorities, to coordinate across organizational levels, and to defend the party line.

This authority matters because it gives the national party unit a stronger claim to define *the* party position and resolve intra-party disagreement. If one party unit is seen as possessing greater authority to define the party line, then following its position can appear as following the party's official line and advancing party unity rather than merely choosing between signals. In this sense, authority does not automatically produce unity, but it provides a heuristic to decide which position to treat as unity-preserving. Partisans may therefore interpret regional dissent from the national position as a challenge to party cohesion.

This matters because unity is strategically important to both parties and partisans. Voters tend to reward parties that appear united (Lehrer, Stöckle and Juhl, 2022), while visible intra-party conflict reduces party attractiveness and shapes how individuals evaluate parties (Klingelhöfer and Müller, 2024). Partisans who value their party's collective standing may therefore have an incentive to align with the cue-giver that appears to be equipped with authority to speak for the party as a whole. Relying on the national party unit becomes a way of supporting the party's authorized strategy and preserving the appearance of unity. In short, the national unit may be treated as the organizational actor with the strongest authority to settle competing party positions.

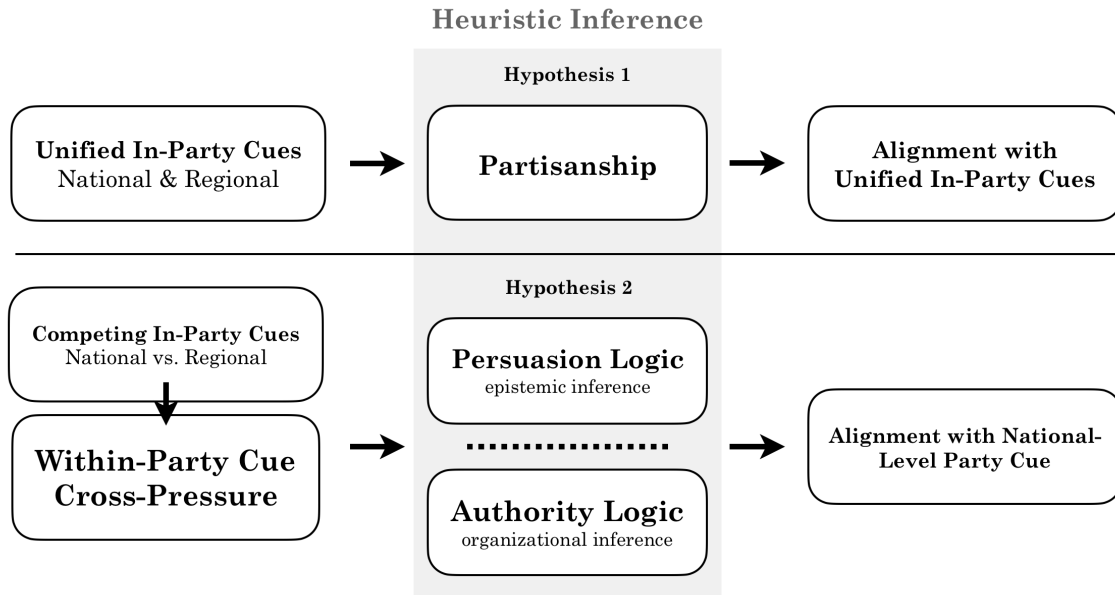
The authority-based mechanism is thus distinct from the persuasion-based one. A partisan may favor the national-level position because it appears more knowledgeable and constrained to be sincere. But a partisan may also place greater weight on it independent of such judgments, because the national party unit is perceived as the authoritative core of the party organization and aligning with it preserves perceived unity. The former is an epistemic inference where partisans assess relevant behavioral criteria of party units. The latter is an organizational inference, where partisans leverage multi-level parties' perceived distribution of internal authority and attune to party unity-seeking objectives.

While distinct, these two inferential logics are not mutually exclusive, however. Partisans may rely on both simultaneously, reinforcing the same conclusion. The national party unit may be perceived as more persuasive while also being regarded as more authoritative in defining the party line. Nonetheless, the observable implication of either theoretical mechanism or their combination remains that partisans are more likely to follow the national-level cue under within-party cue cross-pressure.

Hypothesis 2: National-Level Influence under Cue Competition

Under within-party cue cross-pressure, partisans' policy support is more strongly influenced by the position of the national party unit than by the position of the regional party unit.

Figure 1: Theoretical model



Comment: Unified in-party cues from the national and regional levels lead to unidirectional alignment, as partisanship serves as a straightforward and clear shortcut in reasoning. Cross-pressure from competing in-party cues induces heuristic inference (persuasion or authority-based), resulting in greater influence of the national-level cue.

The theoretical mechanisms are summarized in Figure 1. When partisans encounter conflicting cues from their preferred party across levels of government, they are unlikely to treat the cue-givers equally. To the extent that partisans perceive the national system level as politically primary, the national party unit is likely to be seen as more persuasive and/or more authoritative in defining the party line. Partisans should therefore resolve within-party cue cross-pressure by inferring the superiority of the national-level cue and placing greater weight on it in political judgment. When partisans encounter a unified cue, in contrast, such inferences are not necessary and partisans can use the unified cue as a direct shortcut.

The argument is subject to scope conditions. It assumes that partisans perceive national and regional party units as distinct cue-givers and attach hierarchical meaning to the political levels these actors represent. The mechanism should therefore apply most clearly in multi-level systems where parties operate across recognizable governmental levels and where the national arena is commonly perceived as the primary locus of party-wide representation and accountability. The expected national-level advantage may weaken where regional arenas are perceived as equally or more consequential, where party attachments are strongly territorially anchored, or where the policy issue is understood as primarily regional. Under such conditions, regional party actors may appear more knowledgeable, more authoritative, or more directly accountable than the national party unit.

Research Design

The thesis uses a three-arm online vignette experiment fielded with a convenience sample of 124 Austrian partisans in Spring 2026 to test whether exposure to conflicting in-party cues reduces support relative to unified endorsements (H1) and whether, under divergence, respondents' policy support is more strongly influenced by the national than by the regional party cue (H2). This section justifies the Austrian case and describes the sampling strategy, the experimental treatments and outcome measures, and outlines the estimation strategy and the role of explorative analyses.

Case Selection

Austria is selected as a typical case of a European multi-level party system characterized by territorially differentiated governance and nationally integrated party competition. It combines meaningful subnational authority, e.g. in areas such as energy policy, housing, and healthcare, with a stable and nationally coordinated party system. Political parties are organized across national, regional, and local levels, with regional branches playing a relevant role in electoral campaigning while also being responsible for regional policymaking (Deschouwer, 2003; Bolleyer, 2012).

This multi-level structure is directly relevant to the design, as it provides the incentives for co-partisan actors at different territorial levels to adopt distinct policy positions. At the same time, major parties – the Christian-democratic People's Party (ÖVP) and Social Democratic Party (SPÖ), the populist-right Freedom Party (FPÖ), the liberal party NEOS and an ecological party (Die Grünen) – compete across all nine federal states and are represented in both regional and national governments, making it likely that within-party cue competition regularly unfolds across the party spectrum.

This combination of vertical party integration (Deschouwer, 2003; Thorlakson, 2009, 2013) and the degree of subnational autonomy (based on V-Dem indicators; Coppedge *et al.*, 2026; see discussion in Appendix C) is crucial for observing within-party cue cross-pressure: it allows policy positions to diverge across levels and foresees regional branches that are recognized as semi-autonomous entities, while also ensuring that individuals attribute signals of all party units to the same overarching party brand. Clear ideological differentiation and relatively low party system fragmentation further facilitate voters' ability to form partisan attachments to these party entities. Together, these features make Austrian partisans an appropriate population for examining how individuals process and respond to conflicting intra-party cues.

However, within the population of European political systems Austria also deviates in several aspects. In comparison, it combines relatively strong subnational authority with a highly integrated party system (Thorlakson, 2009; Coppedge *et al.*, 2026). In more strongly regionalized systems, greater decentralization often coincides with territorially distinct party competition (e.g. Belgium, Spain),

limiting the comparability of co-partisan cues across levels in terms of persuasiveness and party hierarchy. By contrast, in more centralized systems like France, regional party units play a less important role and within-party cue cross-pressure as defined in this thesis is not expected to have strong consequences on partisan cue-taking.

Sample

The survey was administered in Qualtrics in German between March 3rd and April 9th 2026. A total of 219 respondents were recruited using social media distribution, snowball sampling, and in-person street-level recruitment. Recruitment was conducted continuously over the fielding period, with repeated outreach efforts and variation in channels to increase participation and improve territorial diversity. Despite these efforts, overall participation remained limited.⁴

Entry into the sample is restricted to respondents who are eligible to vote in Austria (aged 16 or older) and who report feeling close to one of the five major party organizations mentioned before. These criteria are measured prior to random assignment using items adapted from the Austrian National Election Study (AUTNES). After applying these restrictions and excluding respondents who did not complete the primary outcome measure, the final sample consists of 124 respondents. Random assignment yielded treatment groups of nearly equal size (41, 40, and 43 respondents). The restriction to Austrian partisans, i.e., voters who expressed feeling at least a little closer to one party, is necessary, as party cue effects can only be meaningfully assessed among respondents who identify with a party.

The use of a convenience sample and the relatively small achieved sample size reflect practical constraints of this thesis. While the sample limits external validity, prior research suggests that experimental treatment effects estimated from convenience samples are comparable to those obtained from population-based samples in many settings (Mullinix *et al.*, 2015). Although the sample is not population-representative, random assignment ensures internally valid comparisons across treatment conditions within the sample. The comparability of treatment groups on observed pre-treatment characteristics is assessed formally in the Estimation Strategy section, with results reported in Appendix E, Table 1.

At the same time, the limited sample size reduces statistical power and the precision of estimated effects, increasing the risk of Type II error (Campbell, Cook and Shadish, 2001; Cohen, 2013). Therefore, the design is sensitive to comparatively large treatment effects, while modest differences may remain undetected. This applies especially to testing H2 which relies on a comparison between the two divergence conditions.⁵ Accordingly, null findings should be interpreted with caution, as they may

⁴ Specifics on recruitment, survey setup and questionnaire are provided in Appendix B.

⁵ A formal assessment of statistical power for the planned contrasts is provided in Appendix D.

reflect limited precision rather than the absence of substantively meaningful effects. These constraints do not threaten the internal validity of the treatment effects, but they do require caution when generalizing beyond the sample and when interpreting null results.

Experimental Conditions

After passing eligibility requirements, respondents are randomly assigned to one of three treatment conditions. Each respondent receives a news article-style vignette, for example, the unified endorsement condition translated to English in Figure 2 below. All three treatment conditions in English and the German original are reported in Appendix A.

The first part of the news article describes a hypothetical policy proposal in a domain with shared federal-state competences: electricity-market regulation and grid access. The second part describes the policy positions of the respondents' national party unit and unspecified state party unit. No individual elites or specific state party units are named to avoid introducing additional reputation- or competence-based considerations that might be attached to e.g. specific state party leaders or members of regional or national parliaments and governments.⁶

Figure 2: Unified Endorsement Condition

In the electricity system, the number of new feed-in installations (e.g., photovoltaic systems, battery storage) is increasing. At the same time, regional bottlenecks are emerging in distribution grids. To manage grid access and accelerate procedures, **a technical reform package** is currently being discussed. The proposal includes:

- uniform technical connection standards for new installations above a certain capacity (e.g., controllability during grid congestion),
- an accelerated, digital connection procedure, allowing provisional approvals based on standardized data and conditions in cases of congestion,
- a transparent capacity management system that prioritizes grid access in regions facing bottlenecks.

The **[Party] national party organization** *supports* the proposal and refers to its balanced approach to grid expansion, security of supply, and fair costs for households and businesses.

A **[Party] state party organization** *also supports* the proposal and highlights that it represents a balanced solution between technical steering, security of supply, and cost fairness.

⁶ To account for possible reputational effects as a supplementary robustness test, respondents were asked if they thought about any specific regional unit (see Appendix B for setup and results).

Presentation of cues in a hypothetical news article was chosen as previous research shows that text-based treatments sufficiently simulate real-world information environments (Skytte, 2025) and realistically encourage heuristic policy evaluation (Boudreau and MacKenzie, 2014). A text-based presentation was also easier to administer than e.g. video- or radio news reports. Both cues are presented symmetrically in wording, length, and placement, ensuring that differences in responses can be attributed to cue divergence rather than to differences in presentation or context. Key elements of the manipulation are visually emphasized to ensure attention and recognition.

Given that cue effects are sensitive to issue selection (Tappin, 2023) and framing (Chong and Druckman, 2007; Slothuus and de Vreese, 2010), the design carefully addresses both. The issue is selected to be institutionally relevant at both levels of government. Competencies related to the electricity system are shared across levels and debates on policies with shared responsibilities regularly involve both national and regional actors. This makes cues from both levels plausibly legitimate in the eyes of respondents. Within-party cue cross-pressure, as conceptualized in this thesis, is only meaningful when competing cues originate from actors with comparable legitimacy to speak on the issue, which would not be the case if the issue responsibility were clearly designated to only one level of government.

The hypothetical proposal is deliberately constructed as a technical reform package and is therefore expected to evoke only weak affective reactions and limited value-based considerations (Tavits, 2007). Respondents are not expected to hold a great deal of expertise and strong priors on the issue, likely increasing reliance on heuristics (Lupia and McCubbins, 1998; Bullock, 2011, 2020). Furthermore, the hypothetical article does not directly frame the divergence as intra-party turmoil or conflict, but merely mentions the divergent positions in sequence to avoid introducing additional framing effects (Chong and Druckman, 2007; Slothuus and de Vreese, 2010).

The only feature that varies across groups is the stance attributed to two party units of the respondent's preferred party, as presented in Table 1: the national (*Bundespartei*) and a state party unit (*Landespartei*). In the unified condition (group 1), both party units support the proposal. In the two divergence conditions, the party units take opposing positions. In group 2, the national unit supports while the state unit criticizes. In group 3, this configuration is reversed.

Table 1: Experimental Conditions

Group	Condition	National Party Unit	State Party Unit
1	Unified Endorsement	supports	supports
2	Divergence	supports	criticizes
3	Divergence	criticizes	supports

The unified endorsement condition allows to test the first hypothesis, that unified cues have a stronger effect than divergent cues, while the two mirrored divergence conditions introduce conflicting in-party cues. The design does not include a control condition absent information of party positions or direction of endorsement, as the theoretical focus lies on how partisans resolve intra-party disagreement rather than on whether party cues matter per se.

Central to identification is the use of two mirrored divergence conditions. A single divergence condition would confound the organizational level of the cue with the direction of endorsement. By reversing which party unit supports the proposal, the design allows observing whether respondents systematically align with one party level across both configurations. At the same time, because endorsement direction, party level, and speaker order vary jointly, it is not possible to causally distinguish whether responses are driven by party level (national vs. state), by the direction of endorsement (support vs. criticize), or the order of cues. The estimates therefore capture respondents' net alignment under cross-pressure rather than the independent effect of each component. Distinguishing between these components would require a more comprehensive design that varies endorsement direction, party level, and cue order separately, which is beyond the scope of this thesis.

Measurement Strategy

The primary outcome measure captures respondents' expressed support for implementing the proposal on a 7-point Likert scale. Thereafter, three theoretically relevant post-treatment mechanism items capture respondents' perceived differences between the national and regional party units. The first two items relate to the persuasion-based logic and capture whether respondents perceive the national party unit, compared to the regional party unit, to hold more relevant policy knowledge and to face stronger reputational punishment if it supported a flawed proposal. The third item relates to the authority-based logic and captures whether the national party unit is perceived as having greater authority to define the party's official position than the regional party unit.

These measures were collected post-treatment because asking respondents beforehand could have primed them to think explicitly about party-unit differences before evaluating the proposal. They are therefore used descriptively to assess whether the inferential logics specified in the theory are plausible in respondents' evaluations after vignette exposure. Respondents are thereafter asked to provide an open-ended explanation of their judgment to further explore why respondents may follow one party unit over the other. The treatment vignette remains visible while respondents answer the questions up until this point in the survey, ensuring that consecutive evaluations are made with direct reference to the presented information.

Finally, respondents are provided with manipulation checks, asking whether the national and state party unit respectively supported or opposed the proposal. The survey concludes with demographic items (state of residence, political interest, left-right self-placement, age cohort, gender, education level) and a debrief reminding respondents of the hypothetical nature of the scenario described in the treatment vignette (see Appendix B).

Ethical Considerations

The design follows standard ethical principles for online survey-based research, including informed consent, data protection and minimization of harm. Prior to participation, respondents were informed about the survey's purpose, data usage, and their rights under GDPR, in line with the consent form provided for master theses in Political Science at the University of Gothenburg (see Appendix B) and were asked for explicit consent. Participation was voluntary and respondents were informed that they could withdraw consent at any time. Contact details of the research project were provided for transparency. No identifying data were collected.

The experiment involves the use of deception, as respondents were exposed to a fictitious policy proposal and hypothetical co-partisan party unit positions. This was necessary to ensure internal validity and to isolate responses to within-party cue cross-pressure in an experimental setting. To mitigate potential harm, several safeguards were implemented. The hypothetical nature of the vignettes was signaled prior to treatment and reiterated in the survey debrief. In addition, no real politicians or specific state party units were named, mitigating the risk of reputational harm or misleading inferences about real-world party competition.

The study includes respondents aged 16 and above, reflecting the legal voting age. This is necessary to capture a realistic sample of Austrian partisans. In total, 15 respondents fall within the 16-24 age group, making it possible that underaged individuals participated. It should be acknowledged that underaged participants are potentially more susceptible to deception than adult respondents. However, the survey content is non-sensitive and the vignettes resemble standard political communication found in news reporting, making them appropriate even for this group of underaged respondents.

Overall, the study is expected to pose minimal risk to respondents. Experimental treatments typically do not produce lasting attitudinal effects beyond the immediate study context (Clifford, Sheagley and Piston, 2021; Tappin and Hewitt, 2023). Furthermore, data collection took place during a period without ongoing regional, national, or European elections, additionally reducing the likelihood that the study interfered with real-world political processes or electoral decisions.

Estimation Strategy

Each hypothesis is evaluated using difference-in-means OLS regressions across experimental conditions. The 7-point outcome measure is treated as approximately continuous in the primary analyses, with robust standard errors and 95% confidence intervals reported throughout. Robust standard errors are used to account for possible heteroscedasticity. The main analyses follow an intention-to-treat logic and are conducted on the full sample of 124 respondents. Given the non-probability recruitment strategy but random assignment to treatment conditions, inference is restricted to internally valid experimental estimations within the achieved sample (Keele, McConaughy and White, 2012; Lavrakas, 2025).

Balance checks indicate that the treatment groups are broadly comparable across most observed pre-treatment characteristics. Fisher's exact tests reveal no statistically significant differences in party preference, age, education, or state of residence (Appendix E, Table 1). However, *political interest* is unevenly distributed across conditions ($p = 0.016$), and *gender* differences are borderline significant ($p = 0.050$). The primary specification therefore reports unadjusted difference-in-means OLS estimates, consistent with the logic of random assignment, alongside a second specification adjusting for the two pre-treatment covariates that show imbalance. Fully adjusted models including the full set of measured covariates are reported in Appendix E as additional robustness tests.

For H1, mean support in the unified endorsement condition is compared to mean support in the pooled divergence conditions. The two divergence conditions are pooled because both share the defining feature of cross-pressure while differing only in which party level endorses the proposal and which is mentioned first. This estimand thus captures whether conflicting in-party cues reduce support relative to unified endorsements, as formalized in equation 1:

$$E[Y | T = 1] > E[Y | T \in \{2, 3\}]^{(1)}$$

For H2, mean support is compared between the two divergence conditions, capturing the relative weight respondents place on national- versus regional-level cues under cross-pressure. If respondents follow the national cue to a larger extent than the regional cue, the mean of group 2 (national in favor, regional in opposition) should be higher than the mean of group 3 (regional in favor, national in opposition), as this would indicate that respondents align with the national-level cue. The expectation is formalized in equation 2:

$$E[Y | T = 2] > E[Y | T = 3]^{(2)}$$

Robustness & Heterogeneity

The results of a manipulation check are presented after the hypothesis tests, assessing whether the results depend on successful recall of the cue configuration. In brief, the results are robust to these alternative specifications. In principle, H1 and H2 treatment effects may vary by party preference, strength of party preference, or political interest. In the present study, however, the combination of a small overall sample and three treatment arms would leave too little statistical power for interaction models or subgroup comparisons to yield informative estimates. Any observed differences would be highly unstable and difficult to distinguish from sampling noise. For this reason, supplementary heterogeneity analyses are not pursued.

Exploratory Analyses

In an exploratory analysis, the post-treatment items pertaining to the potential theoretical mechanisms of knowledge, reputation constraint, and authority attribution will be leveraged. In this analysis, I first present mechanism items descriptively across treatment conditions. Second, I examine possible differences between the two divergence groups using regression models. Because these measures are collected post-treatment they cannot be interpreted as stable priors, thereby leaving the causal direction underlying these measures unanswered. Yet this analysis allows assessing whether the mechanism components are plausible to appear as stable considerations in respondents' reasoning across conditions.

To explore the implications of congruent versus divergent in-party signals and response strategies further, the final qualitatively-inspired analysis examines open-ended responses to the question: "*In the scenario you just read, you were presented with information about the positions of the [Respondent's Party] national party and a state party organization. Can you briefly explain in two to three sentences how this information influenced your decision about the proposal?*". These are coded using both inductive and deductive approaches to identify interpretations of within-party cue competition beyond the hypothesized direction. The qualitatively-inspired analysis therefore focuses on descriptive summaries of themes and provides illustrative excerpts, aiming to characterize how respondents articulate their judgment both in the absence and presence of within-party cue cross-pressure.

Declaration of AI Usage

I used AI-based tools in limited and supportive ways during the preparation of this thesis. Consensus.App was used at an early stage to help identify a potential research gap and support the literature search. DeepL was used to support grammar correction and translation from my German mother tongue into academic English. ChatGPT was also used to assist with coding analytical steps in R, including troubleshooting and structuring parts of data preparation. All substantive decisions regarding design, theoretical argument, analysis, interpretation, discussion, and conclusion remained my own responsibility. No AI was used to generate text.

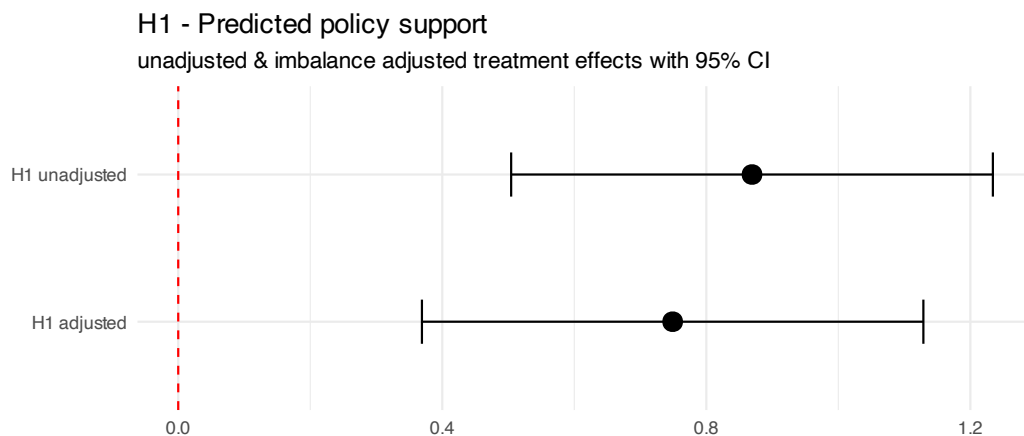
Analysis

The analysis proceeds in three steps. First, I test H1 and H2 using the OLS specifications outlined above, followed by a brief formal assessment of robustness. Second, I explore the extent to which theory-based mechanisms are present and stable in respondents' perceptions after exposure. Third, I analyze the answers to the open-ended question to better understand partisans' reactions to the experimental conditions.

Hypotheses Tests

The *Unified Endorsement Effect* hypothesis (H1) states that average support among partisans for a policy proposal is higher when the national and a regional party unit of their preferred party jointly endorse the proposal than when these units express opposing positions. To test this expectation, I assess whether policy support is significantly higher in the unified endorsement condition than in the pooled divergence conditions in an OLS regression. Figure 3 below plots the predicted policy support, with the first model presenting the raw H1 estimate without adjustment for sample imbalances, while the second model presents the adjusted estimate. Numeric results are presented in Table 2, Appendix E. Overall, the results support the first hypothesis.

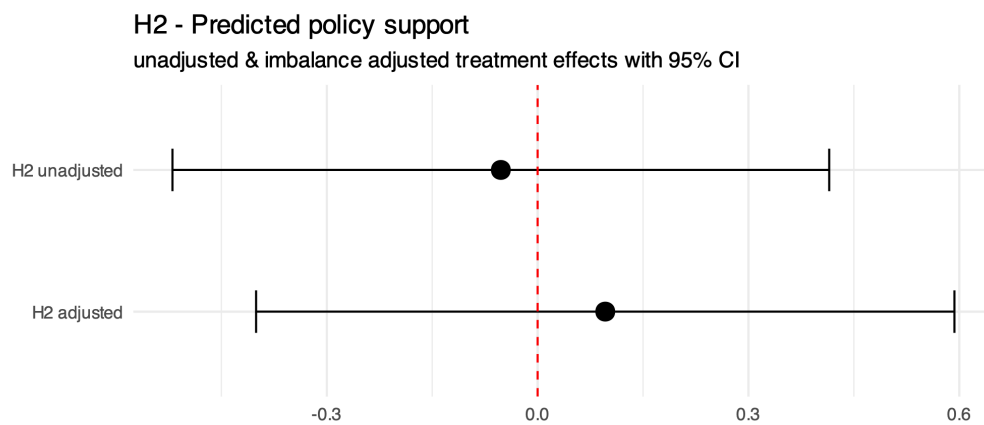
Figure 3



Assignment to the unified endorsement condition, relative to the pooled divergence condition, is associated with an increase of ~0.83 standard deviations or ~0.87 points in policy support ($p < 0.001$). Substantively, respondents exposed to congruent cues from both party levels express nearly one response category more support for the proposal than respondents exposed to divergent cues. After adjusting for gender and political interest, the estimated effect remains similar in size and statistically significant with a coefficient of ~0.75 points ($p < 0.001$) or ~0.72 standard deviations. The fully adjusted model 3 reported in Appendix E, Table 2 yields the same substantive conclusion. The results are therefore consistent with the first expectation that unified in-party endorsements provide a clearer signal than cross-level disagreement for heuristic inference, resulting in higher average policy support.

The *National-Level Influence under Cue Competition* hypothesis (H2) states that under within-party cue cross-pressure, partisans' policy support is more strongly influenced by the position of the national party unit than by the position of the regional party unit. In practice, this means that among respondents exposed to divergent cues, policy support should be higher when the national party unit supports the proposal than when it opposes it. Following the same logic as for testing H1, Figure 4 below plots the unadjusted estimate and the estimate after adjusting for sample imbalances (numeric results in Table 3 Appendix E).

Figure 4



The evidence presented does not provide support for H2, as the estimates for national-level influence fail to show a statistically significant difference in both the unadjusted and adjusted models. The estimated effects correspond to only -0.05 standard deviations in the unadjusted model and 0.09 standard deviations in the imbalance adjusted model. This does not support the expectation that respondents follow the national-level cue more strongly than the regional-level cue under within-party cue cross-pressure. A fully adjusted model in Table 3, Appendix E replicates this result.

This null finding should be interpreted with caution. Because the estimates rely on comparing the two divergence conditions rather than pooling them, the test is based on a smaller effective sample than the test for H1. As a result, the design offers limited precision for detecting modest differences between these groups (see discussion in Appendix D). The absence of a statistically significant effect should therefore not be interpreted as definitive evidence that national-level influence is absent but could be due to a lack of statistical power.

Overall, the evidence does not support the hypothesis that, under within-party cue competition, respondents react more strongly to a national party cue than to a regional party cue. While H1 reveals a clear difference between congruent and divergent in-party cues, the H2 comparison suggests that once within-party cue competition occurs, the relative dominance of the national party unit cue is not clearly observable in the primary outcome measure. The implications of this null result for the proposed theoretical preference between co-partisan signals under conflict are taken up in the discussion section.

Robustness Checks

To assess whether the main findings are sensitive to alternative model specifications, I re-estimate the unadjusted and imbalance-adjusted H1 and H2 models on the subsample of respondents who correctly recalled the treatment conditions in the post-treatment manipulation checks. The substantive conclusions remain unchanged for both hypotheses across specifications (Appendix E, Table 4 and Table 5). This suggests that the results are not driven by respondents who failed to pass the manipulation check. While additional sub-group heterogeneity tests based on respondents' political interest, strength of partisanship, and party preference would have been interesting to explore, given the small sample size I refrain from conducting such tests.

Mechanism Exploration

In a next step I examine whether persuasion- and authority-based considerations are visible in respondents' post-treatment perceptions. The persuasion-based argument expects partisans to place greater weight on the cue of the party unit perceived as more knowledgeable and more constrained by reputational costs. The authority-based argument, by contrast, expects partisans to place greater weight on the cue of the party unit perceived as having greater authority to define the party line.

Respondents across all conditions were asked to provide their opinion on knowledge, reputational constraint, and authority statements: "When comparing the [Respondent's party] national and state party organizations, to what extent do you agree or disagree with the following statements?" These statements capture whether the national party unit, relative to the state party unit, possesses the respective attribute (exact statement wording in Appendix B). Because these items were measured after exposure to the vignette, they cannot show which heuristic respondents relied on when forming their judgment, nor can they establish the causal direction between perceived cue-giver attributes and policy support. Instead, they are used as exploratory diagnostics of how respondents perceived the national relative to the state party unit under cue divergence on theoretically relevant criteria. Given the absence of systematic support for H2, the analysis cannot demonstrate that respondents relied on these perceptions as heuristics. It can only provide tentative evidence on whether the considerations underpinning the hypothesized inferential logics were present in the sample.

Across the full sample, respondents tended to evaluate the national party unit somewhat more favorably than the state party unit on all three measures.⁷ The strongest average agreement appears on the authority item, where respondents tended to agree that the national party has greater authority to define the party line ($\text{Mean}_{\text{pooled}} \cong 3.91$, $\text{SD} = 0.86$, where 4 = "rather agree"). Agreement was clear but more moderate

⁷ It should be noted that it is a possibility that the statement wording has partly led to the favorable evaluations of the national-level party unit across surveyed mechanism criteria. The result is not robust to the possibility that responses would be different if the statements were stated in reverse order.

on the reputational-constraint item ($\text{Mean}_{\text{pooled}} \cong 3.42$, $\text{SD} = 1.06$) and the knowledge item ($\text{Mean}_{\text{pooled}} \cong 3.27$, $\text{SD} = 0.98$). Descriptively, this suggests that respondents did not perceive the party units as equivalent in theoretically important ways. After exposure, they tended to attribute somewhat greater authority, reputational constraint, and policy-relevant knowledge to the national party unit, which is in line with the theoretical arguments.

This is also broadly consistent within the theoretical framework, but these full-sample descriptives cannot show whether such perceptions functioned as plausible rules to resolve cue conflict. Assessing this plausibility, I compare the three items between the two divergence conditions only. This comparison is exploratory and should not be interpreted as evidence of causality. Since the items were measured after treatment exposure, differences between divergence groups may reflect how respondents evaluated the cue configuration they encountered rather than stable prior considerations of national and state party units. The comparison is nevertheless informative because it shows whether perceptions vary with the specific speaker order and pattern of endorsement and criticism.

Figure 5

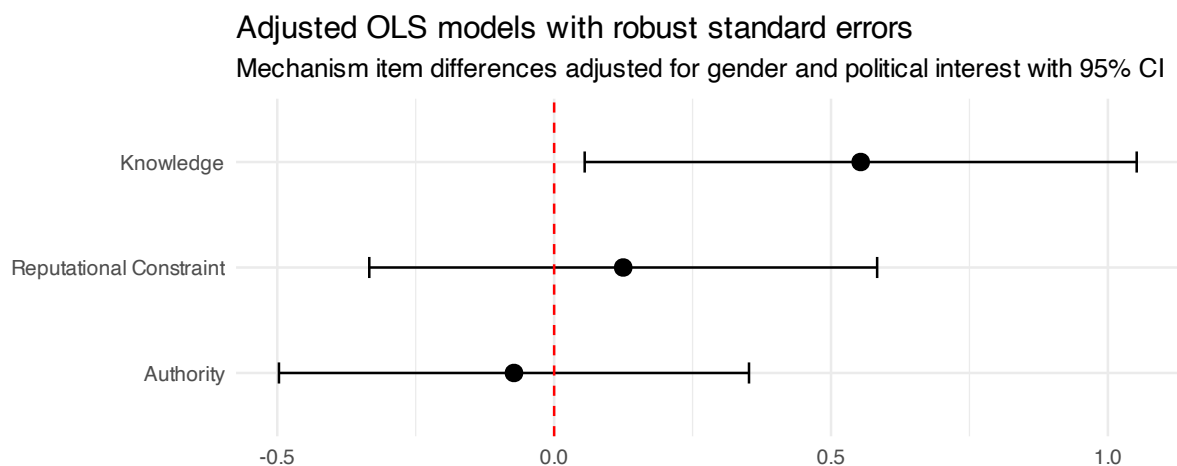


Figure 5 above plots adjusted regression estimates with 95% confidence intervals for each item between the two divergence conditions (for numerical results see Appendix E, Table 6). The clearest perceptual difference appears on the knowledge item. Respondents in group 2 express significantly stronger agreement than respondents in group 3 with the statement that the national party unit is better informed about the implications of the policy proposal (adjusted difference = 0.554, $p < 0.05$). Respondents attribute greater policy-relevant knowledge to the national party unit when it endorses and the state party unit opposes the proposal compared to when this configuration is reversed. This complicates the interpretation of perceived knowledge as a stable criterion for resolving cue competition. It may instead partly reflect how respondents made sense of the specific configuration they encountered after exposure.

If respondents genuinely treated the national party as more knowledgeable, more reputationally constrained, or more authoritative prior to forming their policy judgment, this pattern should also appear when the national party criticizes the proposal and the state party supports it. The knowledge results contradict this expectation. Perceived knowledge varies across the two divergence configurations, which makes it harder to interpret this item as a stable prior criterion for resolving cue competition. Instead, knowledge attributions may partly reflect how respondents made sense of the specific cue configuration they encountered. This pattern is therefore more consistent with post-treatment rationalization, where evaluations of cue-givers are shaped by respondents' emerging view of the proposal rather than preceding it as an independent heuristic criterion (Kunda, 1990).

By contrast, the adjusted models provide no evidence that perceptions of reputational constraint or authority vary systematically between the two divergence conditions. In combination with the relatively high full-sample means on these measures, this is more compatible with the theoretical argument. Respondents exposed to divergent cues generally perceived the national party unit as more authoritative and somewhat more reputationally exposed, regardless of endorsement configuration and speaker order that differed between divergence conditions. Nevertheless, these perceptions still did not translate into the behavioral pattern as expected by H2. Respondents did not express higher support when the national party endorsed the proposal than when it criticized it. This finding suggests that even relatively stable national-level authority or responsibility perceptions were not sufficient to structure policy support under within-party cue cross-pressure.

Taken together, the post-treatment mechanism items show that respondents did not treat the two co-partisan cue-givers as interchangeable. The full-sample descriptives suggest a general tendency to evaluate the national party unit more favorably. However, perceived knowledge varies with the specific divergence configuration, suggesting that respondents' competence attributions may partly reflect the endorsement pattern or speaker order they encountered rather than a stable prior consideration for cue-following. Reputational constraint and authority, on the other hand, appear less sensitive. Despite their stability they do not produce the behavioral national-level cue-taking pattern expected by H2.⁸ The mechanism-item results should nevertheless be interpreted cautiously, as the sample-size limitations that affect H2 also constrain the precision of comparisons between the two divergence conditions on the mechanism measures.

The evidence therefore neither confirms nor rules out the persuasion- or authority-based logic. It more cautiously suggests that respondents differentiated between party units in relevant ways, while the relationship between these attributions and policy support remained ambiguous. This matters because

⁸ Additional regression models on the pooled divergence groups subsample provide no robust evidence that agreement with these perception measures are associated with policy support (Appendix E, Table 7).

these findings cannot show how respondents themselves connected within-party disagreement, party-unit attributes, and their eventual policy judgment. The next section therefore turns to open-ended responses, which do provide insight into how respondents described their reasoning independently.

Open-Ended Responses

The data contains 61 open-ended responses to the question: “In the scenario you just read, you were presented with information about the positions of the [Respondent’s Party] national party and a state party organization. Can you briefly explain in two to three sentences how this information influenced your decision about the proposal?” The analysis of these responses serves as an explorative tool. It assesses whether respondents explicitly invoked one of the three theoretical components when explaining their decision, or whether they relied on other forms of reasoning entirely.

Responses were coded using both a deductive and inductive approach. This allowed identifying references to the theoretical components of knowledge, reputational constraint and authority, while also capturing themes beyond the theoretical arguments. Because a single response could contain more than one theme, the coding is non-exclusive and a response could be assigned to multiple themes. Table 8 in Appendix E reports the resulting counts of coded themes. Figure 6 below presents these counts as shares within each treatment group. All excerpts used in the main text are translations by the author.

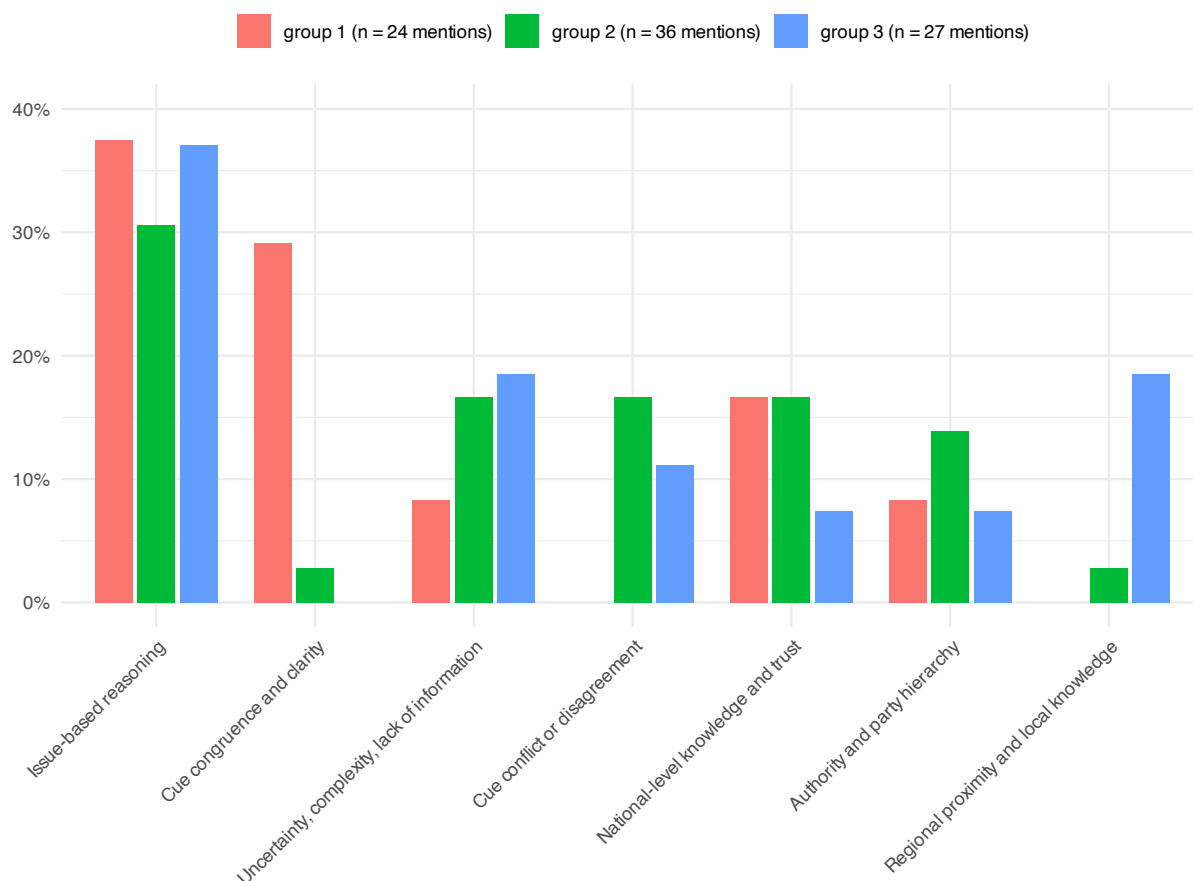
Deductively Coded Responses

I first examine the themes that correspond directly to the theoretical argument, beginning with the persuasion-based components of perceived knowledge and reputational constraint, and then discussing the authority-based component. This makes it possible to assess whether respondents themselves invoked the considerations that the theoretical argument identifies as plausible bases for resolving within-party cue competition.

Among the themes related to the theoretical mechanisms, the most frequently mentioned theme relates to *national-level knowledge and trust*. Mentions of this theme appear twelve times overall and make up 17% of coded themes in group 1 and group 2 respectively. These responses suggest that some did not treat the two co-partisan cue-givers as equally informed. Instead, they explicitly distinguished between national and state party units in terms of perceived professionalism, a broader perspective to account for, or a general information surplus. To exemplify, one group 2 respondent states: “*I think the federal party should be better advised; sometimes I can’t quite take the state parties seriously.*” This response does not just express agreement with national signals but attributes higher credibility to the national party unit, while also discounting the state party as a less serious source of endorsements. Another group 2 respondent makes a similar distinction but frames state-level cues less dismissively: “*[The] state party is more ‘hands on’ and involved in local issues, while at the federal level there is more focus on the big*

picture and, in my view, a generally more professional approach.” Here, the respondent does not deny that the state party has relevant knowledge. Rather, they differentiate between local embeddedness and national-level strategic overview. The two responses resemble the persuasion-based logic closely, viewing the national party unit as better positioned than the state party unit to assess broader political implications.

Figure 6: Share of coded theme mentions per treatment group



However, the qualitative material also shows why perceived national-level competence might not necessarily generate full alignment with the national-level cue. One group 3 respondent explains: “[I] have changed my stance from strongly in favor to somewhat in favor, because the national party should not only take local interests into account but also address issues of broader relevance.” In signaling the reduction in support after being exposed to criticism by the national party unit, this response clearly indicates that national-level criticism has value. However, the formulation shows that countervailing considerations introduced by the national party unit only entail an incremental reduction in support for the proposal. In sum, the respondent seems to incorporate national-level credibility considerations while still maintaining support for the proposal. This broadly aligns with the evidence and interpretation presented in the mechanism test above – even where greater competence or broader overview is attributed to the national level, this did not necessarily translate into national-level cue-following but was instead weighed against other available considerations.

The second component of the persuasion-based argument, perceived reputational constraint, is much less visible in the open-ended responses. References to reputational consequences do not appear frequently enough to define an independent coding theme. Few respondents explicitly describe one party unit as facing stronger consequences if the proposal later turned out to be flawed. This is substantively informative. While the closed-ended mechanism item suggested that respondents tend to attribute somewhat greater reputational exposure to the national party unit, respondents rarely invoke this consideration on their own terms when explaining their judgment freely. Reputational constraint may therefore be a plausible consideration when respondents are directly asked about it, but it appears less central in their own accounts of how they process the cues.

The third theoretical component concerns the authority-based argument. References to authority and party hierarchy appear nine times overall. In alignment with the theory, these show that some recognize differences in organizational standing. However, the responses do not indicate a simple pattern in which respondents automatically treat the national party as the authorized source providing *the* party line. One group 2 respondent notes that the “*State and federal party organization belong together in principle, so their consequences are relatively similar, even though they are two distinct entities. Federal is larger and more powerful...*” While recognizing differences in size and power, this respondent does not draw a sharp hierarchical conclusion from that observation on policy judgment.

A group 1 respondent makes the ambivalent consequences for policy support even clearer: “*I think it’s pretty complex in principle. My idea is that the federal party should steer national policy matters and have the final say. At the regional level, state chapters won’t let themselves be pushed around and are better informed about local conditions. For some reason, I trust the national party more than the state parties.*” This respondent articulates a theoretical tension of the authority-based argument. Both party units are credited with different types and not degrees of legitimacy to provide policy endorsements. The national party unit is perceived as having final authority over national policy matters, while the state party unit is equipped with local knowledge and organizational autonomy. The final statement of greater trust in the national level should therefore not be interpreted as arising from a purely hierarchical view. This respondent’s tendency to trust the national party unit more coexists with the recognition that regional branches are endowed with authority in their respective domain. In consequence, they cannot simply be reduced to subordinate cue-givers.

Taken together, the mechanism-related responses provide only partial support for the considerations underlying the persuasion- and authority-based arguments. Respondents did at times invoke national-level knowledge, professionalism, trust, or authority when explaining their judgment. However, these considerations are rarely applied as straightforward decision rules that would make the national-level cue prevail under divergence. The deductive codes therefore help identify traces of the proposed

mechanisms, but they do not fully explain how partisans deal with cue conflict. This raises the question of other forms of reasoning respondents rely on when in-party cues become ambiguous.

Inductively Coded Responses

The inductively developed codes point to a different set of reasoning strategies beyond the mechanisms specified in the theory: regional proximity and local knowledge, issue-based reasoning, and expressions of uncertainty under cue conflict. These themes help explain why within-party cue divergence did not produce a clear national-level resolution pattern.

A first inductively developed theme concerns *Regional proximity and local knowledge*, appearing most frequently in group 3 (18% of coded themes in this group), where the state party unit supports and the national party unit criticizes the proposal. This theme is analytically important because it points to an alternative basis for assigning credibility. One respondent in this group notes that the “*state party is closer to the people. For the federal party, the primary focus is on the electoral goal of winning power.*” Another respondent in this group argues: “*The information provided by the state party seems to me to be more in line with citizens’ wishes and to ensure energy security for households in an emergency.*” This suggests that some resolve cue conflict by privileging the state party’s proximity to affected citizens and giving weight to local implementation concerns.

Given that this form of reasoning is almost exclusively present in group 3, in which respondents were exposed to a supportive regional-level cue first and an opposing national-level cue second, respondents in this group might have formed their judgment on the regional cue first. They may then have engaged in post-hoc rationalization of this choice, emphasizing the regional party unit’s local knowledge and proximity to citizens’ concerns. This would indicate that the results in hypothesis 2 might have been inconclusive due to an ordering effect rather than a true lack of a systematic heuristic resolution strategy under divergence. Cue conflict would then be responded to with independent reasoning and cue evaluation that supports an already emerging policy judgment. This explanation is more consistent with a solution strategy of within-party cue cross-pressure built on the principles of motivated reasoning, where individuals process political information in ways that support a preferred conclusion (Kunda, 1990; Leeper and Slothuus, 2014).

This possibility directly connects to a second theme that emerged inductively. *Issue-based reasoning* is by far the most frequent theme in the material, with 30 coded mentions across the 61 responses and at considerable levels across the treatment groups (about 48, 31, and 47 percent in groups 1, 2, and 3). The volume of this theme across groups suggests that many did not resolve the scenario by selecting one party unit as the superior cue-giver. Instead, some justified their decision by referring to the substantive content of the proposal, prior knowledge, or pragmatic considerations about electricity-system

regulation. This does not mean that party cues are irrelevant. Rather, it suggests that within-party cue cross-pressure may not simply redirect partisans to hierarchical considerations in preference formation but reduce the usefulness of the party cue and push some toward systematic policy evaluation.

Some respondents appear to rely on issue-based reasoning instead of pursuing the hypothesized strategy of heuristically deciding among competitive co-partisan cue-givers. A group 2 respondent states: *“I read through both sets of arguments and considered them in light of my understanding of the article. My decision was based on the substantive arguments and was independent of the political context.”* The presence of competing co-partisan signals here appears to lead partisans toward evaluating substantive policy arguments independent of party signals. Hence, the prevalence of systematic rather than heuristic processing in the qualitative material is central for interpreting the broader results. Under divergence, some did not simply choose between the national and state-level cues. Instead, they turned towards the proposal itself, pointing to an important implication for cue effects: when the in-party speaks with two voices across levels of government, the cue may lose some of its heuristic usefulness. In such situations, partisans may respond not by following the more persuasive or authoritative cue-giver, but by relying more heavily on issue-based reasoning, prior knowledge, or pragmatic policy evaluation.

Issue-based reasoning is also dominant within group 1, in which respondents were not even exposed to divergent cues. One reason for this may be that respondents bring prior knowledge of the issue into the evaluation. This is illustrated by one group 1 respondent: *“My work currently involves a lot of focus on the topic of ‘energy,’ so I’m already quite well-informed on the subject. In this case, it wasn’t my political affiliation that was the deciding factor, but rather my professional opinion on the matter.”* This response presents the judgment as grounded in issue-specific knowledge rather than partisan affiliation. However, this quote does not allow establishing whether issue-based reasoning fully preceded the respondent’s policy support or whether it partly served as a post-hoc justification of a position that was also consistent with the supportive party cue. The quote should therefore be interpreted cautiously, showing that respondents issue-specific knowledge could override, or at least coexist with, reliance on party cues.

The final inductively generated themes connect the open-ended responses back to the main treatment effects most clearly. References to *Cue congruence and clarity* appear almost exclusively in group 1 (29% of coded themes in group 1) while references to *Cue conflict or disagreement* appear only in the divergence conditions. One group 1 respondent explicitly noted that the *“The [Respondent’s Party], at both the state and federal levels, have earned further trust when it comes to energy policy. The consistency between state and federal positions has further contributed to this.”* This illustrates the mechanism behind the unified endorsement effect in practical terms. Cross-level agreement makes the party position clearer and increases trust in the party’s endorsement.

The divergence conditions show the opposite pattern. References to *Uncertainty, complexity, lack of information* are more common when respondents encounter divergent cues. One group 2 respondent states: “*The proposal sounds good to me but am not well informed in this area. Due to the critique of the state party, I have reduced my support from strongly in favor to in favor.*” This response captures the support-dampening effect of within-party cue cross-pressure particularly well. The respondent still finds the proposal appealing, but the state party’s criticism introduces enough uncertainty to weaken support. Others focus on ambiguity more directly. Two group 3 respondents write: “*Difficult, I have trusted my gut feeling.*” and “[...] *to make a reliable assessment of whether this makes sense, more detailed information would be needed.*” These responses do not indicate clear reliance on either the national or state party cue. Instead, they suggest that divergent cues can leave partisans without a sufficiently clear heuristic basis for judgment.

Overall, the open-ended responses suggest that cue congruence matters because it makes party cues more usable for political judgment. Unified endorsement clarifies the party position and retains the heuristic value of the cue. Divergence, on the other hand, appears to make the information environment more ambiguous. Some invoke the theoretically expected considerations such as national-level knowledge or authority, yet others emphasize regional proximity and local knowledge, and many turn to effortful and systematic issue-based reasoning. The qualitative material therefore supports the main implication of the unified endorsement effect (H1) while helping to interpret the weak national-level influence result (H2). Within-party cue cross-pressure does not consistently redirect partisans to consider relative persuasiveness or authority between party units across levels of government. In this sample, it instead appears to reduce cue clarity and encourages more heterogeneous forms of reasoning, including issue-based reasoning and systematic, system 2 forms of judgment.

Discussion

The findings suggest a twofold answer to how partisans react to divergent in-party cues across levels of government. Congruent cues increase support by preserving the clarity and heuristic value of the party signal. Divergent cues, by contrast, do not appear to redirect partisans toward the national party as the superior cue-giver, but instead seem to generate more heterogeneous forms of reasoning in the formation of policy judgments.

When the national and state party units jointly endorse a proposal, average support is clearly higher than when the two party units disagree. This supports the unified endorsement expectation (H1) suggesting that cue congruence preserves the usefulness of party cues as a straightforward heuristic and helps partisans form policy preferences (Bullock, 2020), while divergence weakens cues’ impact. This pattern is also consistent with qualitative responses in which clear party signals are trusted more and explicitly expressed to increase policy support. Unified endorsement thus strengthens a party’s capacity to guide

partisan opinion and increase support for its policy endorsements among its voters. This is in line with previous research demonstrating that party unity can positively affect public perceptions and evaluations of parties (Lehrer, Stöckle and Juhl, 2022; Klingelhöfer and Müller, 2024).

However, when national and regional party units disagree, partisans in this sample do not appear to resolve the divergence by systematically treating the national party unit as the more persuasive or authoritative cue-giver (H2). Average support is almost identical across the two divergence conditions, and the qualitative evidence points to heterogeneous forms of reasoning rather than a dominant national-level resolution strategy. Contrary to the expectation derived from Lupia and McCubbins' (1998) theory of persuasion and the authority-based argument developed in this thesis, favorable national-level cue-giver assessments do not translate into systematic national-level cue-taking. Divergence therefore seems less to redirect partisans toward a superior party cue-giver than to reduce the heuristic value of in-party signals. This is further substantiated by the analysis of mechanism items and open-ended responses. These highlight that while partisans perceive the national level as more knowledgeable, reputationally constrained and to have more authority to define the party line, this does not translate into national-level cue-following or referring to these considerations when explaining support or opposition for a policy proposal.

In addition, the mechanism tests indicated that knowledge attributions may partly be shaped by the treatment itself. The underlying theoretical implication is not that these considerations are absent in partisan minds when their preferred party disagrees across levels of government. But instead, that cue-giver assessments themselves may become a product of the judgment process. The fact that the knowledge measure varies across the two divergence configurations suggests that cue-giver evaluations may be shaped by the specific cue environment and/or respondents' emerging policy judgment. This pattern provides tentative support for an alternative explanation grounded in motivated reasoning (Kunda, 1990; Petersen *et al.*, 2013; Bullock, 2020), namely that evaluations of party units fall in line with an already emerging favorable view of the proposal. Perceived cue-giver knowledge may therefore appear as a post-hoc justification for the policy judgment, rather than as the prior basis for a heuristic judgment of the policy as implied by the dual-process perspective.

Distinguishing between these two interpretations is not possible at this point, since the design cannot establish the causal order between policy evaluations, the measurement of perceived cue-giver attributes, and cue-taking. Yet the sum of findings in the divergence conditions – the null result for H2, the variation in perceived national-level knowledge across the two divergence groups, and the overall dominance of issue-based reasoning in the qualitative material – suggests that partisan cue-taking and cue-giver evaluations are shaped to a greater extent by respondents' systematic evaluation of the policy

proposal than previously expected. The absence of a statistically significant H2 effect implies that the partisan reliance on hierarchy-based heuristics in the population are modest at best.

In sum, the empirical findings are in line with previous research showing that cue effects reduce when challenged by prior knowledge, contradicting considerations, or available policy information (Bullock, 2011; Boudreau and MacKenzie, 2014; Peterson, 2019). But, contrary to previous research that finds a strong influence of cue-giver hierarchy under intra-party conflict (Agadjanian, 2020; Filindra and Harbridge-Yong, 2022), the findings cannot substantiate the claim that such a hierarchy significantly structures partisan opinion formation in the examined context. A possible explanation is that I studied cross-level policy disagreement between institutionalized party units in a European parliamentary system rather than in-party critiques of leadership misconduct (Filindra and Harbridge-Yong, 2022) or counter-intuitive policy cues between elites in the US presidential system (Agadjanian, 2020). It is likely that partisans rely on different reasoning strategies when disagreement occurs over substantive policy, when disagreement emerges between collective actors in the form of party units across levels of government, and when the broader information environment, including the degree of elite polarization (Druckman, Peterson and Slothuus, 2013), differs.

While there are plausible theoretical explanations for the lack of empirical evidence for a national-level dominance in cue-taking, the reason for the null results might also be empirical. An important design limitation to consider is that these findings rest on a small convenience sample of Austrian partisans. Random assignment supports internally valid contrasts, but the estimates should not be interpreted as population-level effects. This limitation is especially consequential for testing H2 and the interpretation of mechanism tests, which rely on the comparison between the two divergence groups only. The findings from this sample show that H2 is not supported and knowledge attributions depend on the configuration of divergence, but they do not rule out the possibility of modest national-level dominance and stable perceived knowledge advantages for the national party unit in the broader population.

The design is limited in three additional aspects. First, the three-arm design cannot fully separate party level, endorsement direction, and speaker order. The findings suggest either that supportive cues may have carried more weight than critical cues, or that respondents reacted to the party cue mentioned first, or both. Second, the closed-ended mechanism items were measured after treatment exposure to avoid priming respondents' subsequent vignette evaluation. These measures can therefore only be interpreted as post-treatment perceptions rather than stable attributions of theoretically relevant cue-giver criteria. Third, the chosen electricity-system regulation domain may have enabled more substantive reasoning than expected. Some respondents appeared well equipped to evaluate the proposal on its substantive merits, which may have weakened the applicability of the proposed heuristic mechanisms.

Conclusion

In this thesis, I aimed to examine how partisans respond when their preferred party sends conflicting policy cues across the national and regional levels of government. While previous research has investigated several influences on partisan cue-taking, such as individual-level political sophistication or strength of partisanship (Bullock, 2020) and system-level polarization (Druckman, Peterson and Slothuus, 2013) or issue salience (Lecheler, de Vreese and Slothuus, 2009), cue-givers are primarily treated as unitary actors that speak with one voice. This assumption, however, is unlikely to hold in multi-level systems of government in which subnational parties hold considerable policy responsibility and have incentives to diverge from the national party line.

In addressing this gap, I first argued that unified endorsements retain the heuristic value of cues. Second, I argued that within-party cue cross-pressure turns partisans to secondary heuristics that privilege signals from the national party unit. The behavioral expectation is that these inferences make the national-level party unit appear more persuasive and/or more authoritative. I tested these expectations with a three-arm online vignette experiment among 124 Austrian partisans, comparing unified endorsement to two mirrored divergence conditions and complemented the insights gained from the experimental evidence with explorative tests of the underlying mechanisms and insights from open-ended responses. The results show that unified endorsements significantly increase policy support relative to within-party divergence, indicating that congruence maintains the value of party cues as heuristic shortcuts. However, the findings do not show that respondents systematically follow the national party unit under divergence. Instead, open-ended responses point to more heterogeneous forms of reasoning, involving strategies based on national-level trust, regional proximity, and issue-based evaluation.

The theoretical contribution therefore is that in-party cues in multi-level contexts should be understood in terms of signal coherence across party levels, given that multiple co-partisan party units communicate simultaneously on the same subject. The findings suggest that cue-taking becomes more contingent when collective actors from within one's preferred party send competing signals. Furthermore, divergence reduces cue clarity without necessarily activating a stable hierarchy-based rule for resolving cue-giver disagreement. The thesis shows that cue-giver attributes such as knowledge, reputational constraint, and authority generally travel in the expected direction in favor of the national party unit. However, these criteria do not appear to provide a systematic basis for partisans to draw secondary heuristics from. While cue-giver attributions may precede and therefore influence cue-taking among some partisans, most of them seem to give greater weight to various other considerations in forming policy judgments. Some partisans may even only construct cue-giver evaluations once required to justify an already emerging policy view. This implies that future research should treat cue-taking under within-party disagreement as a contingent process between competing in-party signals in the information environment, cue-giver evaluations, and emerging views on the policy substance itself.

Several limitations and scope conditions qualify these conclusions. Empirically, the study relies on a small convenience sample, which limits external validity and reduces precision of the H2 comparison between the divergence conditions. The three-arm design also cannot fully separate party level, endorsement direction, and speaker order, while the mechanism items capture respondents' perceptions after vignette exposure rather than stable prior beliefs about national and regional party units. Beyond these design limitations, the findings are also likely to depend on the context in which within-party cue cross-pressure occurs. The argument should apply most clearly when national and regional levels are meaningfully differentiated and possess legitimacy to engage in policy disagreements, when the issue is sufficiently complex or unfamiliar for party cues to matter as heuristics. The chosen electricity-system and grid access reform involved shared national and regional responsibilities, which may have made both party units appear highly legitimate and allowed some respondents to reason substantively instead of heuristically about the proposal. In policy areas with more clearly assigned policy responsibilities, and where partisans hold weak prior attitudes and limited expertise, partisans may resolve cross-level disagreements differently and one party level's influence may be stronger.

Future research should build on these limitations by using larger and more comprehensive experimental designs that vary party level, endorsement direction, and cue order independently. It should also compare policy domains in which respondents have different levels of prior attitudes and expertise and in which national and sub-national responsibilities are more clearly differentiated. Beyond territorial party units, future studies should examine whether similar response patterns emerge when cue competition unfolds among individual national-level party actors, regional branches, factions, party leaders, individual officeholders, and local or regional elites. Certain individuals and collective actors may be more persuasive and authoritative than others under specific circumstances. Such an extension would also speak to Druckman's (2021) critique that persuasion research has paid little attention to competitive communication environments in which multiple actors simultaneously seek to shape opinion. A further avenue is to measure theoretically relevant cue-giver criteria both before and after treatment exposure, making it possible to distinguish whether knowledge, reputational constraint, and authority attributions guide cue-taking or are constructed during the process of justifying the policy judgment itself. Research in this direction should more precisely clarify both the empirical conditions under which party cues retain or lose their heuristic value and the theoretical mechanisms through which partisans navigate policy disagreement within their own party.

After all, the results carry implications for both party communication and democratic accountability. For parties, a practical implication is that successful cue-giving in multi-level systems is conditional on the perceived unity of the party across levels of government. Cross-level disagreement appears strategically costly because it reduces cue clarity and weakens the party's capacity to guide partisan opinion. If parties fail to manage such disagreement transparently, they also risk broader public fallout,

as unclear signals may undermine trust in party communication and distance voters from policy debates. Parties in multi-level systems should therefore avoid sending contradictory messages across levels of government or provide clearer justifications when disagreement is unavoidable. For democratic accountability, however, the implications are more ambivalent. If within-party cue cross-pressure leads some partisans to rely less on party signals and more on effortful, issue-based forms of reasoning, intra-party disagreement may interrupt automatic cue-following and encourage closer scrutiny of co-partisan elite signals. In this sense, competitive co-partisan persuasion may, under some conditions, foster more substantive engagement with policy arguments and therefore carry potential democratic benefits.

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Appendix

Appendix A. Treatment Conditions

Treatment Conditions (English)

In the electricity system, the number of new feed-in installations (e.g., photovoltaic systems, battery storage) is increasing. At the same time, regional bottlenecks are emerging in distribution grids. To manage grid access and accelerate procedures, a **technical reform package** is currently being discussed. The proposal includes:

- uniform technical connection standards for new installations above a certain capacity (e.g., controllability during grid congestion),
- an accelerated, digital connection procedure, allowing provisional approvals based on standardized data and conditions in cases of congestion,
- a transparent capacity management system that prioritizes grid access in regions facing bottlenecks.

Unified Endorsement: National Support, State Support	Divergence 1: National Support, State Critique	Divergence 2: State Support, National Critique
The [Party] national party organization <i>supports</i> the proposal and refers to its balanced approach to grid expansion, security of supply, and fair costs for households and businesses.	The [Party] national party organization <i>supports</i> the proposal and refers to its balanced approach to grid expansion, security of supply, and fair costs for households and businesses.	A [Party] state party organization <i>supports</i> the proposal and refers to its balanced approach to grid expansion, security of supply, and fair costs for households and businesses.
A [Party] state party organization <i>also supports</i> the proposal and highlights that it represents a balanced solution between technical steering, security of supply, and cost fairness.	A [Party] state party organization <i>criticizes</i> the proposal and highlights that it represents an unbalanced solution between technical steering, security of supply, and cost fairness.	The [Party] national party organization <i>criticizes</i> the proposal and highlights that it represents an unbalanced solution between technical steering, security of supply, and cost fairness.

Treatment Conditions (German original)

Im Stromsystem steigt die Zahl neuer Einspeiser (z. B. Photovoltaik, Batteriespeicher). Gleichzeitig kommt es regional zu Engpässen in den Verteilnetzen. Um den Netzzugang zu steuern und Verfahren zu beschleunigen, wird derzeit **ein technisches Reformpaket** diskutiert. Der Vorschlag umfasst:

- einheitliche technische Anschlusskriterien für neue Anlagen ab einer bestimmten Leistung (z. B. Mess- und Steuerbarkeit bei Netzengpässen),
 - ein beschleunigtes, digitales Anschlussverfahren, bei dem vorläufige Zusagen auf Basis standardisierter Daten erfolgen und bei Engpässen Auflagen möglich sind,
 - ein transparentes Kapazitätsmanagement, das in Regionen mit Engpässen Prioritäten für den Netzzugang festlegt.
-

Unified Endorsement: National Support, State Support	Divergence 1: National Support, State Critique	Divergence 2: State Support, National Critique
Die [Party] Bundespartei <i>unterstützt</i> den Vorschlag und betont dessen ausgewogene Balance zwischen Netzausbau, Versorgungssicherheit und fairen Kosten für Haushalte und Betriebe.	Die [Party] Bundespartei <i>unterstützt</i> den Vorschlag und betont dessen ausgewogene Balance zwischen Netzausbau, Versorgungssicherheit und fairen Kosten für Haushalte und Betriebe.	Eine [Party] Landespartei <i>unterstützt</i> den Vorschlag und betont dessen ausgewogene Balance zwischen Netzausbau, Versorgungssicherheit und fairen Kosten für Haushalte und Betriebe.
Eine [Party] Landespartei <i>unterstützt</i> den Vorschlag ebenfalls und hebt hervor, dass es sich um eine ausgewogene Lösung zwischen technischer Steuerung, Versorgungssicherheit und Kostenfairness handelt.	Eine [Party] Landespartei <i>kritisiert</i> den Vorschlag und hebt hervor, dass es sich um eine unausgewogene Lösung zwischen technischer Steuerung, Versorgungssicherheit und Kostenfairness handelt.	Die [Party] Bundespartei <i>kritisiert</i> den Vorschlag und hebt hervor, dass es sich um eine unausgewogene Lösung zwischen technischer Steuerung, Versorgungssicherheit und Kostenfairness handelt.

Appendix B. Survey Setup

<i>Question</i>	English Translation	German Original	Response Format / Note
<i>consent</i>	Would you like to participate in this study?	Möchten Sie an dieser Studie teilnehmen?	Yes / No (screen out “No”).
<i>eligiblevote</i>	Are you eligible to vote in Austria? (16 years or older)	Sind Sie in Österreich wahlberechtigt? (16 Jahre oder älter)	Yes / No (screen out “No”).
<i>partypref1</i>	In Austria, some people feel close to a particular political party, even if they occasionally vote for another party. How about you? Generally speaking, do you feel close to a political party?	In Österreich stehen einige Leute einer bestimmten politischen Partei nahe, obwohl sie ab und zu auch eine andere Partei wählen. Wie ist das bei Ihnen? Stehen Sie im Allgemeinen einer politischen Partei nahe?	Yes / No (go to partypref2 if “No”)
<i>partypref2</i>	Do you feel at least a little closer to one particular party than to the others?	Stehen Sie denn einer bestimmten Partei zumindest ein wenig näher als den anderen Parteien?	Yes / No / Don’t Know. (screen out if “No” or “Don’t Know”)
<i>partypref_party</i>	Which party is that?	Um welche Partei handelt es sich dabei?	ÖVP / SPÖ / FPÖ / NEOS / Grüne / Prefer not to say; Response is piped into [Insert Party] fields
<i>depvar (primary outcome variable)</i>	To what extent do you support implementing the proposal?	Inwieweit unterstützen Sie die Umsetzung des Vorschlags?	7-point scale, 1 = strongly oppose / 7 = strongly support; Treat as approx. continuous in primary analyses
<i>mc</i>	When comparing the [Insert Party] national and state party organizations , to what extent do you agree or disagree with the following statements?	Wenn Sie die [Insert Party] Bundes- und Landesparteiorganisationen miteinander vergleichen, inwieweit treffen die folgenden Aussagen zu?	introduction question
<i>mc_knowledge</i>	Compared to the state party, the national party is better informed about the political implications of the proposal.	Im Vergleich zur Landespartei ist die Bundespartei über die politischen Auswirkungen des Vorschlags besser informiert.	6-point scale, 1 = strongly disagree / 5 = strongly agree / 6 = Don’t Know; Matrix format
<i>mc_reputation</i>	Compared to the state party, the national party would face more serious consequences if it supported a proposal that later turns out to be flawed.	Im Vergleich zur Landespartei hat die Bundespartei mit schwerwiegenden Konsequenzen zu rechnen, sollte sie einen Vorschlag unterstützen der sich später als schlecht erweist.	
<i>mc_authority</i>	Compared to the state party, the national party has greater authority to define the party line in this policy area.	Im Vergleich zur Landespartei hat die Bundespartei mehr Autorität die Parteilinie in diesem Politikfeld festzulegen.	
<i>recognition1</i>	When reading the scenario, did you have a specific [Insert Party] state party in mind?	Haben Sie bei der Situation, die Sie gerade gelesen haben, an eine bestimmte [Insert Party] Landespartei gedacht?	Yes / No (go to recognition2 if “Yes”)
<i>recognition2</i>	If yes, which [Insert Party] state party did this scenario make you think of?	Wenn ja, an welche [Insert Party] Landespartei hat Sie diese Situation erinnert?	[Insert Party] Wien / [Insert Party] Niederösterreich / [Insert Party]

			Burgenland / [Insert Party] Steiermark / [Insert Party] Kärnten / [Insert Party] Oberösterreich / [Insert Party] Salzburg / [Insert Party] Tirol / [Insert Party] Vorarlberg
<i>openend</i>	In the scenario you just read, you were presented with information about the positions of the [Insert Party] national party and a state party organization. Can you briefly explain in two to three sentences how this information influenced your decision about the proposal?	In der Situation, die Sie gerade gelesen haben, haben Sie Informationen über die Position der [Insert Party] Bundes- und einer Landesparteiorganisationen gesehen. Können Sie in zwei bis drei Sätzen näher erläutern, wie diese Informationen Ihre Entscheidung zu diesem Vorschlag beeinflusst haben?	used descriptively as a qualitative component; question wording was refined through piloting to explicitly prompt respondents to reflect on how the provided information influenced their reasoning and judgment, which improved expected analytical clarity and relevance of responses.
<i>mancheck1</i>	According to the text: Did the [Insert Party] national party support or oppose the proposal?	Laut Text: Hat die [Insert Party] Bundespartei den Vorschlag unterstützt oder kritisiert?	Support / Oppose / Don't know
<i>mancheck2</i>	According to the text: Did the [Insert Party] state party support or oppose the proposal?	Laut Text: Hat die [Insert Party] Landespartei den Vorschlag unterstützt oder kritisiert?	Support / Oppose / Don't know
<i>residence</i>	In which federal state do you live?	In welchem Bundesland leben Sie?	Wien / Niederösterreich / Oberösterreich / Burgenland / Steiermark / Kärnten / Salzburg / Tirol / Vorarlberg / Prefer not to say
<i>polinterest</i>	Generally speaking , how interested are you in politics?	Einmal ganz allgemein gesprochen: Sind Sie an Politik ...	5-point scale, 1 = very interested / 4 = not interested at all / 5 = Don't know; Proxy for Sophistication.
<i>leftrightself</i>	In politics, people often refer to “left” and “right.” Where would you place yourself on a scale from 0 to 10 , where 0 means “left” and 10 means “right”?	Man spricht in der Politik immer wieder von "links" und "rechts". Wo würden Sie sich selbst auf einer Skala von 0 bis 10 einordnen , wobei 0 "links" bedeutet und 10 "rechts" bedeutet?	0 (Left) / 1 / 2 / ... / 9 / 10 (Right) / Prefer not to say
<i>age</i>	Which age group do you belong to?	In welcher Altersgruppe sind Sie?	16 – 24 / 25 – 34 / 35 – 44 / 45 – 54 / 55 – 64 / 65 or older / Prefer not to say
<i>gender</i>	What is your gender?	Welches ist Ihr Geschlecht?	Male / Female / Diverse / Prefer not to say
<i>education</i>	What is the highest level of education you have completed?	Was ist Ihr höchster abgeschlossener Bildungsabschluss?	Pflichtschule / Lehre/BMS / Matura/BHS / Fachhochschule/Universität / Sonstiges / Prefer not to say; Categories mirror standard Austrian attainment levels

Survey Recruitment

The goal of survey recruitment was to achieve territorial diversity within the sample; however, it is not intended to match the precise territorial distribution of the Austrian population. Additional recruitment efforts involved, for example, the recruitment of passengers on a long-distance train journey through Austria, which resulted in 15 responses added. In addition to using private Instagram and Facebook channels, the survey was listed on poll-pool.com for the mentioned period, which resulted in 17 additional responses.

Measurement Strategy

To measure party preference, respondents are first asked if they feel close to an Austrian party. If not, they are prompted with a second version, asking if they feel at least a little closer to some party than the others. Provided they have stated “yes” in round one or two, respondents are then asked to indicate which party this is. Those who answer both negatively or select “Prefer not to say” when indicating their party preference, are screened out prior to treatment exposure. This setup mirrors the measurement of party preference in the Austrian National Election Study (AUTNES).

The consecutive measurement strategy distinguishes between a primary outcome question used for hypothesis testing, the expressed support for the policy proposal, additional post-treatment mechanism measures used for descriptive and exploratory purposes, and additional measures used for robustness checks and balance tests. All measures apart from the primary outcome variable were optional to answer and included “Don’t Know” response options to reduce guessing.

The primary outcome measure was placed immediately below the vignette to minimize contamination from subsequent demographic items and to ensure that responses reflect respondents’ immediate reactions to the treatment while the informational context remains salient. The treatment vignette, however, remains visible while respondents answer these questions, ensuring that consecutive evaluations are made with direct reference to the presented information. Only the manipulation checks and demographic items are presented on separate pages and must be answered without access to the vignette.

The measures used for balance checks, i.e. verifying that treatment group composition is balanced, are described in the table on page 42 above and include age cohort, gender, education, state of residence, left-right self-placement, political interest, and party preference. Table 1 in Appendix E reveals a statistically significant imbalance of gender and political interest. The OLS regression analyses therefore are replicated with adjusted specifications to account for these imbalances.

Supplementary Robustness Measure

Initially, a supplementary robustness check was planned to assess the associations respondents found in the treatment vignette, specifically with regard to recognizing a particular state party unit. Comparing those respondents who have and have not reported having a specific state party unit in mind when answering the survey. In the final sample, however, only seven respondents in group 1, eight in group 2, and ten in group 3 reported doing so in the *recognition_1* item. These cell sizes are too small to support meaningful subgroup analysis, and the test is therefore not pursued further. At the same time, the low frequency of state-party recognition suggests that responses were unlikely to be strongly driven by reputational evaluations of specific state party organizations in this sample.

Consent Form

The consent form was on the first page of the survey, originally in German. This is the English translation:

Information on the processing of personal data for educational purposes at the University of Gothenburg and consent to participate in the study

The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) requires that survey participants be informed about how their personal data are processed. This text describes the purpose of the study in which you are participating and the rights you have as a participant. The University of Gothenburg is responsible for the processing of personal data carried out by students as part of their studies. If you have any questions about the processing of your data, you may contact the student conducting the study.

Course code: SK2532

Thesis title: In-Party Cues in Multi-Level Systems

Student: Stefan Höller

Contact address: gushollest@student.gu.se

Purpose of the study

This survey is conducted as part of a student research project at the University of Gothenburg. It examines how people form political opinions when they receive information about political positions attributed to different levels within the same political party, such as the national and state levels. Participants are Austrian citizens eligible to vote who were recruited online to take part in the study. The personal data processed include your survey responses on political attitudes and evaluations, as well as basic background information collected in the questionnaire, such as age, gender, education, political interest, and other non-identifying demographic information. No direct identifiers, such as name, address, or IP address, are collected for the purposes of the study.

Only persons involved in the thesis have access to your personal data: the student himself, Stefan Höller, and the supervisors/examiners. Your responses will be processed only for the duration of the thesis and for educational purposes. After completion of the thesis, the student, Stefan Höller, will delete the responses. This means that no personal data can be requested as public documents. If you would like to read a more detailed description of your rights under the GDPR and find the contact details of the University's Data Protection Officer and the Swedish Authority for Privacy Protection, please visit [Processing personal data | University of Gothenburg](#). By answering the survey, you give your consent. Your participation is voluntary, and you may withdraw your consent at any time until the survey is completed.

Survey Debrief

German Original

Sie haben das Ende der Umfrage erreicht.

Der politische Vorschlag und die genannten Positionen der politischen Parteien waren hypothetisch und spiegeln nicht deren tatsächliche Positionen wider.

Vielen Dank für Ihre Teilnahme an dieser Umfrage!

English Translation

You have reached the end of the survey.

The political proposal and the positions of the political parties mentioned were hypothetical and do not reflect their actual positions.

Thank you for participating in this survey!

Appendix C. Case Selection Indicators

Austria combines a comparatively high degree of regional authority with a nationally integrated party system, making it a suitable empirical setting for studying within-party cue competition in multi-level contexts.

This assessment is based on V-Dem indicators (Coppedge *et al.*, 2026), according to which Austria scores at the upper bound on the V-Dem regional government index ($v2xel_regelec \cong 1$), well above the EU average (0.61), indicating a high degree of autonomy of elected regional governments vis-à-vis unelected actors at the regional level. At the same time, candidate selection remains only partially centralized ($v2pscnslnl = 0.94$; EU average = 0.85), suggesting that candidate selection involves multiple levels of party organization rather than being controlled exclusively by national party elites.

Despite these features, the party system remains nationally integrated. Major political parties compete across most regions ($v2pscomprg = 2.25$), with values comparable to Germany (2.38). In addition, subnational party control varies across regions ($v2pssunpar = 2.38$; EU average = 1.89), indicating that different parties govern across regions, reinforcing that subnational arenas are electorally meaningful rather than dominated by a single party nationwide.

Taken together, these indicators suggest that Austria combines meaningful subnational political authority and some intra-party decentralization with a cohesive national party system. This configuration provides an appropriate empirical setting for examining how voters respond to potentially conflicting cues across party levels.

Appendix D. Statistical Power and Sensitivity

This appendix briefly discusses statistical power and sensitivity of the analysis. Because the empirical analysis relies on both comparisons using once all three treatment groups and once between the divergence conditions only, the power of the design should be evaluated separately for these different comparisons.

For the comparison across the three treatment groups, the final sample yields a statistically significant result. A one-way ANOVA shows that the treatment groups differ overall, $F(2, 121) = 11.06, p < 0.001$. A Welch ANOVA, which does not assume equal variances, leads to the same conclusion, $F(2, 77.69) = 14.07, p < 0.001$. The estimated effect size was $\eta^2 = 0.15$, indicating that treatment assignment explains about 15 percent of the variance in the dependent variable. This corresponds to a substantively meaningful overall treatment effect rather than a trivial difference in policy support across all groups.

At the same time, the study remains limited in its ability to detect comparatively small effects across all three treatment arms. As a benchmark, a balanced one-way ANOVA power calculation using the *pwr* library in R indicates that detecting a small omnibus effect of $f = 0.15$ at $\alpha = 0.05$ with 80 percent power would require roughly 144 respondents per group, or about 432 observations in total. The realized sample of 124 is far below this threshold. The omnibus analysis was therefore not well powered to detect comparatively small treatment differences. The fact that a statistically significant result nonetheless emerges suggests that the observed overall treatment differences between unified endorsement and divergence are sufficiently large to be detectable even in a comparatively modest sample.

The planned contrast for H1, comparing the unified endorsement condition to the pooled divergence conditions, was clearly statistically significant. The estimated standardized effect size is large, Cohen's $d = -0.90$, with a 95% $CI = [-1.29, -0.51]$. This indicates that the study was sufficiently sensitive to detect the comparatively large difference associated with cue congruence versus cue divergence. In substantive terms, the H1 contrast does not appear to be a marginal finding close to the study's detection threshold, but a robust difference of considerable magnitude.

In comparison, the planned contrast for H2, comparing the two divergence conditions directly, was not statistically significant. The estimated effect size is essentially zero, Cohen's $d = 0.05$ with a 95% $CI = [-0.38, 0.48]$. This interval includes both small negative and small positive values and therefore indicates substantial uncertainty around a negligible point estimate. Substantively, the data do not provide evidence of a meaningful directional difference between the two divergence conditions. At the

same time, the design is less sensitive for this comparison than for H1, because H2 rests on two smaller treatment groups and a much narrower expected contrast.

Overall, the achieved sample size appears adequate to detect the comparatively large treatment associated with H1, but less well suited to identifying small or modest differences between the two treatment conditions. The null result for H2 should therefore be interpreted with caution. It is consistent with the absence of a meaningful effect, but it does not by itself rule out smaller effects that this thesis may not have been well powered to detect. The power discussion presented here should therefore be understood as a benchmark for interpreting the sensitivity of the design rather than as a formal ex ante sample size justification.

Appendix E. Supplementary Results

Table 1: Fisher's exact tests of standard demographics

Variable	Categories	N (non-missing)	Test	p-value	Balance
Party preference	5	124	Fisher's exact test	0.228	No clear imbalance
Age	6	116	Fisher's exact test (simulated p)	0.862	No clear imbalance
Gender	3	116	Fisher's exact test	0.050	Imbalance
Education	6	115	Fisher's exact test (simulated p)	0.502	No clear imbalance
Political interest	4	116	Fisher's exact test	0.016	Imbalance
State of residence	8	114	Fisher's exact test (simulated p)	0.545	No clear imbalance

Notes: Reported p-values are based on Fisher's exact tests of independence between each pre-treatment covariate and treatment assignment. For variables with larger contingency tables, simulated p-values based on 10,000 replicates are used. Lower p-values indicate greater evidence of imbalance across treatment groups.

Table 2. Full H1 OLS Results

	H1 (1)	H1 (adj.) (2)	H1 (fully adj.) (3)
Unified endorsement effect	0.869*** (0.163)	0.749*** (0.157)	0.724*** (0.160)
Age			0.050 (0.058)
Gender		-0.023 (0.151)	-0.036 (0.160)
Education			-0.066 (0.100)
Political interest		0.408** (0.142)	0.374* (0.148)
Left-right self-placement			-0.070 (0.069)
State of residence			-0.032 (0.032)
Constant	5.277*** (0.117)	4.135*** (0.509)	4.623*** (0.903)
Observations	124	116	113
R-squared	0.154	0.226	0.254
Residual variance	0.932	0.892	0.911
Robust SEs	Yes	Yes	Yes
Covariates	No	Imbalances	Full set

Notes: Policy Support measured on a 7-point scale, with higher values indicating greater support. Robust standard errors in parentheses. Unified endorsement is coded 1 for group 1 and 0 for group 2 and 3 pooled. National-level influence is coded 1 for group 2 and 0 for group 3 so that positive coefficients correspond to the hypothesized direction. Conventional significance levels: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 3. Full H2 OLS Results

	H2 (1)	H2 (adj.) (2)	H2 (fully adj.) (3)
National-level influence	-0.052 (0.235)	0.096 (0.278)	0.092 (0.328)
Age			0.096 (0.087)
Gender		-0.186 (0.219)	-0.156 (0.239)
Education			-0.174 (0.116)
Political interest		0.317 (0.221)	0.294 (0.236)
Left-right self-placement			-0.046 (0.095)
State of residence			-0.019 (0.048)
Constant	5.302*** (0.162)	4.600*** (0.838)	4.941** (1.471)
Observations	83	79	76
R-squared	0.001	0.062	0.102
Residual variance	1.143	1.131	1.185
Robust SEs	Yes	Yes	Yes
Covariates	No	Imbalances	Full set

Notes: Policy Support measured on a 7-point scale, with higher values indicating greater support. Robust standard errors in parentheses. Unified endorsement is coded 1 for group 1 and 0 for group 2 and 3 pooled. National-level influence is coded 1 for group 2 and 0 for group 3 so that positive coefficients correspond to the hypothesized direction. Conventional significance levels: * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 4. H1 OLS estimates after manipulation checks

	H1	H1 manipulation check	H1 manipulation check (adj.)
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Unified endorsement effect	0.869*** (0.163)	0.868*** (0.174)	0.765*** (0.166)
Gender			0.010 (0.154)
Political interest			0.311 (0.180)
Constant	5.277*** (0.117)	5.344*** (0.132)	4.427*** (0.621)
Observations	124	94	92
R-squared	0.154	0.173	0.21
Residual variance	0.932	0.84	0.821
Robust SEs	Yes	Yes	Yes
Covariates	No	No	Imbalances
Passed Man. Check	No	Yes	Yes

Notes: Policy Support measured on a 7-point scale, with higher values indicating greater support. Robust standard errors in parentheses. Unified endorsement is coded 1 for group 1 and 0 for group 2 and 3 pooled so that positive coefficients correspond to the hypothesized direction. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 5. H2 OLS estimates after manipulation checks

	H2	H2 manipulation check	H2 manipulation check (adj.)
	(1)	(2)	(3)
National-level influence	-0.052	-0.087	-0.062
	(0.235)	(0.267)	(0.314)
Gender			-0.146
			(0.228)
Political interest			0.084
			(0.276)
Constant	5.302***	5.387***	5.355***
	(0.162)	(0.172)	(1.046)
Observations	83	61	60
R-squared	0.001	0.002	0.015
Residual variance	1.143	1.079	1.114
Robust SEs	Yes	Yes	Yes
Covariates	No	No	Imbalances
Passed Man. Check	No	Yes	Yes

Notes: Policy Support measured on a 7-point scale, with higher values indicating greater support. Robust standard errors in parentheses. National-level influence is coded 1 for group 2 and 0 for group 3 so that positive coefficients correspond to the hypothesized direction. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 6: Adjusted OLS estimates of differences in post-treatment mechanism perceptions between divergence conditions

	Knowledge (adj.) (1)	Reputational constraint (adj.) (2)	Authority (adj.) (3)
Group 2 vs. group 3	0.554* (0.248)	0.125 (0.231)	-0.073 (0.214)
Gender	-0.380 (0.248)	0.233 (0.169)	-0.119 (0.148)
Political interest	-0.089 (0.200)	0.061 (0.148)	0.094 (0.118)
Constant	3.829*** (0.778)	2.911*** (0.542)	3.776*** (0.478)
Observations	65	77	77
R-squared	0.093	0.023	0.021
Robust SEs	Yes	Yes	Yes
Covariates	Imbalances	Imbalances	Imbalances

Notes: The coefficient for Group 2 vs. group 3 reports the adjusted mean difference between the two divergence conditions. Models adjust for gender and political interest. Results are similar for unadjusted specifications. Robust standard errors are shown in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 7: OLS estimates of post-treatment perception items on policy support in the pooled divergence conditions

	Policy Support (adj.) (1)	Policy Support (adj.) (2)	Policy Support (adj.) (3)	Joint model (adj.) (4)	Joint model (fully adj.) (5)
Perceived knowledge	0.399* (0.199)			0.391° (0.210)	0.350° (0.175)
Perceived reputational constraint		-0.054 (0.147)		-0.001 (0.161)	0.037 (0.176)
Perceived authority			0.076 (0.167)	0.032 (0.232)	0.041 (0.250)
Gender	-0.244 (0.243)	-0.179 (0.216)	-0.163 (0.216)	-0.241 (0.243)	-0.418 (0.275)
Political interest	0.194 (0.216)	0.299 (0.197)	0.298 (0.204)	0.191 (0.211)	0.077 (0.226)
Age					0.133 (0.101)
Education					-0.049 (0.134)
Left-right self-placement					-0.044 (0.111)
Residence					-0.078 (0.049)
Constant	3.836*** (1.077)	4.868*** (0.979)	4.376*** (0.877)	3.749* (1.428)	4.072* (1.749)
Observations	65	77	77	64	61
R-squared	0.167	0.063	0.063	0.166	0.233
Robust SEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Covariates	Imbalances	Imbalances	Imbalances	Imbalances	Fully adjusted

Notes: Sample is a pooled sample of group 2 and group 3 respondents, the two divergence conditions. Policy Support measured on a 7-point scale, with higher values indicating greater support. Robust standard errors in parentheses. ° $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Supplementary Explanation to Table 7 above:

Perceived knowledge is the only item with a statistically significant association with policy support in the adjusted specification, but this association becomes statistically insignificant in the joint models. Reputational constraint and authority show no comparable association. Theory-related perceptions and policy support therefore seem to be not related in this sample.

Table 8: Distribution of coded themes across treatment groups

#	Coding Theme	Frequency group 1	Frequency group 2	Frequency group 3	Frequency total
(1)	Cue congruence and clarity	7	1	0	8
(2)	Cue conflict or disagreement	0	6	3	9
(3)	National-level knowledge and trust	4	6	2	12
(4)	Regional proximity and local knowledge	0	1	5	6
(5)	Authority and party hierarchy	2	5	2	9
(6)	Issue-based reasoning	9	11	10	30
(7)	Uncertainty, complexity, lack of information	2	6	5	13

Note: Coding is non-exclusive. Individual responses may contain more than one theme. Frequencies therefore do not sum to the number of responses within each treatment group